Sitting at the Throne

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31307729.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Fluff and Crack, Light Angst, She-Ra Anniversary Big Bang 2021, Catra-centric (She-Ra), Post-Canon, Glitra friendship but they fight, Catra does not turn evil she's just upset for a bit, I promise, Lots of Cursing, Character Study, -Ish, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Glimmer Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Self-Harm, They all get therapy, Perfuma a real one for this, Additional Warnings In Author's Note, Chapter 4 has warnings, Chapter 5 has warnings

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English

Series:
Part 6 of Catra Applesauce Meowmeow

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Sitting at the Throne

by AOS100

Summary

My cat sat perched high upon on the shelf, looking down at me with such distaste, and it was in that moment that I realized; I am but a mere mortal, filthy, peasant under the rule of an omnipotent, high-held being. - Me

OR

Catra sits in Glimmer's throne in a moment of absolute power and a god complex for a brief moment while her friends are gone, leading to highly unexpected consequences… for everyone.

Notes

My cat still thinks she is all-powerful like in ancient Egypt and assumes she is caring for me, not the other way around… which is slightly true but whatever.

It was the foundation for this and I was planning on just keeping it crack-humor but it spiraled into something else, that's all I can say. Is it a little cringy? Maybe. Am I still going to finish it? Yes. Is this first chapter a little slow-going because it's setting stuff up? Probably.

This all takes place only a year after the war and does not happen in the same universe as "Immortal? Not Exactly".

I have no beta and I do not own any of the characters :)

See the end of the work for more notes

MEGA Lame Princess

In retrospect, all of this had been Bow's fault. If he hadn't gotten in the way of danger he wouldn't have caused the domino effect that led to the storming of Brightmoon Castle.

The only thing remaining consistent throughout it all was that Glimmer was fucking pissed.

Earlier that week, Catra had gone out with the rest of the Best Friend Squad and a couple of other members from the alliance. Horde Prime's bots were still running on basic orders to 'purify' the planet, but they clearly had no idea what that truly meant, and were stuck wandering around villages, the mere image of them instilling fear in the habitants. That wouldn't have been too much of a problem. The challenge came with getting rid of them. When instigated, the bots went haywire and started shooting at anything and everything until finally self-destructing. The function itself reminded Catra a bit of Entrapta's old Horde bots, something that was also a thorn in their side, but Horde bots were more than just a nuisance as they were so technologically advanced. (No offense, Entrapta)

That having been said, the alliance themselves were sent to deal with each group that popped up, usually Netossa, Spinnerella, and Frosta being the one's who went with the Best Friend Squad as Mermista still hated Catra and refused to be near her unless the catgirl was helping rebuild Salineas. Scorpia and Perfuma were simply too busy for the time being as they were remodeling the Fright Zone for Scorpia while Entrapta was being a hermit in Dryl, inventing whatever it was that one invented during peacetime.

Honestly, Catra didn’t want to know.

But today, apparently everyone was busy so it was just the Best Friend Squad here, standing in another village that was left untouched by Catra’s own conquering only to be swarming with stupid Prime bots.

Bow, for having just ended fighting in a war a year ago, was still far too equipped with dozens and dozens of arrows, some of which had new functions.

Glimmer was the same as Adora, honestly. The pair should have been exhausted from fighting a war nearly their entire lives, but they still bubbled with energy whenever a fight like this came. Their feet shuffling from side to side as magic visibly thrummed through their veins (it was creepy) Catra couldn’t judge though. She also still felt the thrill of adrenaline whenever she went into the field again, and she knew she missed it (just a little).

For child soldiers, they were doing pretty well by Perfuma’s standards. Adora still wouldn’t let go of her dumb jacket though, Bow wouldn’t stop tinkering with arrows, Glimmer still clutched her staff tightly and practiced defensive and offensive runes, while Catra… Catra wouldn’t stop sharpening her claws and occasionally hissing at construction workers that moved just a little too quickly towards her.

It had only been a year though, what could one really expect?

Apparently, however, a year also made Bow rusty. Or at least less alert. While Adora was off in her She-ra form, slicing at bots left and right a few yards away, Glimmer was teleporting between firing cannons, leaving Bow to shoot at bots on his trusty ledge. The bots, for how advanced they were, didn't seem to notice where the arrows were coming from and so Bow had no need for cover.

Catra, tearing her claws through bots and canons, seemed to be the only one who caught the surprisingly stealthy approach of a bot coming behind Bow. She called out to him and he turned in time to pluck an arrow out of his quiver and shoot it, but it was too late. All the other bots were aware of his location now and seven more were converging there. Catra ran to his side, ready to help him deal with the bots surrounding him. They were a few seconds into the fight when an eighth bot made its way to them, some of the ones previously fighting Adora and Glimmer even abandoning the struggle in favor of surrounding the pair on the ledge. At this point, even Adora and Glimmer had noticed the bot’s behavior and Glimmer teleported to Bow’s side, trusting Adora to hold off the other bots.

Bow wasn’t doing great with the close-quarters combat, but he was holding his own, and with Glimmer there now, Catra didn’t feel as pressured about the fight.

Mistakes are inevitable though, at least that is Bow’s defense. A bot had wormed its cannon into position and was ready to fire against the archer before Catra shoved him to the side, leaving her own, *properly* covered midsection to receive a graze of the shot.

With a yelp of pain, Catra flinched back before growling and taking out the bot that had pissed her off. She ignored Bow's calls of concern as she shredded through the last couple of bots, only stopping once she was satisfied with all of them lying on the ground, sparking wires and cracked armor surrounding them.

With the adrenaline of the fight still energizing her, she had barely even recalled her injury. She probably would have forgotten about it had it not been for Bow's insistence that she was not okay and that she needed to see a healer while Glimmer teleported off to get Adora, who was finishing up her own fight.

By the time Catra had said her fifth "I'm fine, Bow," Glimmer poofed in front of her, Adora looking down at her girlfriend's side with a frown and a furrowed brow. Glimmer had already told her.

"Let me heal it," Adora insisted, already reaching a hand out to Catra's.

But Catra saw the thin sheen of sweat on Adora's- no, She-ra's forehead. Adora was tired. Healing her right now would make her collapse. They all knew Adora's limits, even Adora herself, but she was still too stubborn to not push herself. "No, Adora," Catra pushed the hand away gently, "it's fine. It's just a flesh wound. Nothing major. It'll heal on its own." She tried for a reassuring smile, but Glimmer poked at the injured side and it turned into a pained hiss, "Ow, what the fuck, Sparkles?"

"That could still get infected, Catra. And by the sounds of it, you're not okay," Glimmer knew she had the upper hand.

The canon had cauterized the wound on its own so she wasn't bleeding too bad, but she was leaning more and more on Bow, and her forehead was starting to get the same sheen of sweat as Adora, matting down her fur. Every breath stretched her side a bit, and it *hurt dammit* . She was still going to refuse though. As stubborn as Adora was, Catra could be even more stubborn, and after having been out here for hours, holding out her She-ra form and swinging her magical sword around, Adora wouldn't be able to take fully healing Catra's wound. If she started, she would need to finish. There were no half-assed healings when it came to She-ra, especially when paired with Adora.

So, Catra turned to Glimmer, "Know any healing spells?"

Catra knew that Glimmer had plenty of healing spells memorized, 'Yeah, do you want me to heal you instead?"

Catra nodded while Adora looked confused and slightly offended, "Why not She-ra?"

The blonde's girlfriend turned with a sigh, "You're tired, Adora. I can see it. Healing me right now would only leave you drained, and as tired as Sparkles is, her spell isn't going to drain as much from her because she's only partially healing it. Right, Sparkles?"

Glimmer, much to Adora's chagrin, agreed with Catra, "She's right Adora. You need to rest. We left you with the same amount of bots that the three of us took on, maybe even more. I'd prefer if you dropped the She-ra form right now, actually."

Grumbling, Adora shrunk down to her normal size and stumbled slightly, Glimmer stabilizing her before going back to drawing the rune. The blonde sat down on the ledge with a plop, making sure that everyone was aware of the fact that she would much rather be fully healing her girlfriend as she helped said girlfriend down to the ground as well. Catra curled gingerly into Adora's side as she stared at Glimmer finishing up the spell. Catra's fur stood a bit on end, watching a rune be drawn so closely. It reminded her of a certain woman, and she pressed herself more into Adora who sensed her unsettled feeling and wrapped her arms carefully around Catra.

They both knew Glimmer and Micah's magic was different though. It didn't have that bitter smell to it, and the symbols drawn into each rune were typically less malevolent-looking. It made Catra feel better, but she still stiffened a bit when Glimmer rotated the rune to face Catra's side, pushing it towards the wound before it dispersed, leaving Catra's midsection looking less like an oozing red mess and more like an angry pink blotch. Still kind of bad, but an improvement. Catra's main thoughts though, were that her fur was going to take forever to grow back. Especially since it was the warm season.

As predicted, the moment that the group got back to the castle, Adora hit the shower and fell asleep the moment her head hit the pillow. Catra told her to not wait up as she had Bow bandage up her burn and as much as Adora would have liked to resist, she didn't.

Glimmer had gone to shower in her and Bow's room, allowing Bow to profusely apologize to Catra much to her annoyance. She

sat at the table, and Bow just kept repeating, "I am *so* sorry Catra, if I had just been paying more attention-"

Catra cut him off, "It's okay Bow. I'm okay. And… I don't regret it." She gave him a small, but sincere smile as she gave him a little side hug on her way out of the room when he finished.

He was left standing in the room, beaming with the roll of bandages still held loosely in his hand.

"But why does Adora get to gooo," Catra was aware she was being whiny, but it just wasn't fair.

"Because we let Adora take a 24 hour nap and now she can't sit still, you on the other hand, are still injured." Glimmer pointedly looked at Catra's healing burn. It was getting much better, but it still wasn't recommended that she fight.

"Well Adora can just heal me now!"

"We need Adora at her best."

"But if Adora heals me, you get a whole other fighter! Or you could just do another spell thingy!" Catra was waving her hands around desperately.

Adora grimaced, “Glimmer, I really *could* just-”

“I’ll heal you. But on one condition,” Glimmer had sparkles in her eyes and while Catra usually remained wary of them, she really wanted to go to the Crimson Waste with the group.

“Anything!”

“You’re grounded.”

“WHAT?”

“Yup. I want to leave someone here to protect the castle. If you’re healed, you can do that,” she had a smirk plastered on her face and all Catra could do was glare.

“Why don’t you really want me to go?”

Honestly, Glimmer already knew she was going to have to spill. Catra was too smart not to question why Glimmer wanted to keep Catra off this mission so badly, “You… caused quite a ruckus last time you were there Catra. You took over in a day! I just- you’re very recognizable and I have a feeling that if you show up to the deal with Huntara on how to deal with the bots there, then all the gangs are either going to be very happy or very upset that you switched sides. It’ll cause conflict,” Glimmer paused and placed hand on Catra’s shoulder, “It’s because you’re special, honey.”

Catra growled before grumbling that Glimmer could heal her. It made sense, with her still fiery temper Catra could very quickly start a gang fight in the Wastes, and she did not need another guilt problem to deal with.

After another healing spell was cast, Catra briefly wondered if Melog could sense the magic feeling she had on her wound, or if they could feel that she was wounded at all. Sometimes her companion would leave for days at a time, never more than a week, but they came with new knowledge each time. Either about the planet's organisms, its magic, Swiftwind's Horse Revolution, or even that kooky old lady in the woods that Adora had taken her to visit one time.

She kind of hoped they would come by today, seeing as how she was going to be alone for the rest of the day, and maybe even the next, since the meeting with Huntara could go any way bad or good.

The original Best Friend Squad finally left, backed up by Spinerella and Netossa, and stocked with communication pads. Catra found herself feeling incredibly lonely for the first time in months. She wasn't buddy-buddy with Mermista, Entrapta spent all her time with Hordak, and Scorpia and Perfuma were busy, she didn't want to bother them.

She had found herself talking with the head of the Royal Guard, Juliet, a few weeks prior, about strategy but they were barely even acquaintances. Catra hadn't made too many new friends, she was still very much hated by the civilians all over Etheria, and

stepping foot into the market would likely cause another round of people coming up to her and telling her in explicit detail who or what they had lost because of her actions in the war.

She knew she deserved it, but it didn't make it hurt any less. Sometimes she thought that maybe she deserved the hurt that came with it, but Perfuma was adamant about the fact that yes, Catra had made mistakes, but it does not warrant people sending her into panic attacks in the middle of the street because they don't know when to stop, or they just don't want to. Some days are better than others, but as Catra wanders the hallways of the castle, she thinks about how grateful she is for Adora being there on the worst days, and all the other days. She and Adora still struggle with their communication, with their emotions sometimes, but at the end of the day Catra supports Adora and Adora does the same for her. It's nice, she thinks.

To have learned how to support and be supported. Catra only wishes she would have learned it sooner.

Glancing at the guards stationed along the pastel walls of the castle, Catra quickly jumps and scales her way up one of the arcs next to a guard. She can tell she spooked the poor girl with such a sudden move, but refrains from sending a sheepish smile to keep from embarrassing her. Her claws dig into the stone of the arc until she makes it to the centerpoint, and readies herself to leap onto the next one. She leaps from arc to arc until she finds herself in front of the throne room, parallel to the war room. She finds it funny that she could have gone anywhere in the castle but she still came back to the one place she feels most useful in.

She could have gone to her and Adora's room, but Adora's not here and it's just not the same. The war room provides a sense of familiarity to her. Even without a war, meetings are still held there, it's where she goes every week to be assigned to Salineas- if Mermista's in the mood to accept, and it's where she plans out strategies to be used against the bots when needed.

And the throne room, well Glimmer's taken to dragging her there at least once a week as well, always finding new records to be organized and labeled- something Catra had grown to be great at in her time commanding the Horde.

She sighs though, "No one's here… nothing for me to do…" she doesn't have the zoomies at the moment, and she doesn't feel like trying to conjure them up. She could nap, but Glimmer had technically assigned her to protect the castle. Maybe she'd find something in the throne room. Better to get ahead with whatever Glimmer would have her do later anyway.

She casually rolls off the arc, her mind not really registering the fall until she finds herself twisting and turning to land on her feet in front of the guards. These don't startle like the other girl had, and Catra wonders if she's one of Juliet's new peacetime recruits or she just hasn't got to Catra falling from random places at random times. With an internal shrug, she pushes the doors open and steps into the throne room, which is relatively cleaner and much more spacious than whenever Glimmer brought her desk in here and cabinets to work.

Maybe Sparkles wasn't actually that messy.

She stands in the middle of the room and the throne at the far back nonexistent wall catches her attention. She walks up the steps leading to the throne, feeling exposed with all the space in this room. Seeing the throne be backed up against nothing and floating she wonders why the throne of the Queen of Brightmoon was so exposed. Sure there were several windows in the oval-shaped room, and a large set of doors at the front which blocked the view of the Moonstone, but to have nothing protecting the throne's backside? It didn't make any sense to her, and she found it weird that she had just now registered it, after months of having been in here. Maybe Glimmer's cabinets had taken up so much space that her brain registered it as a wall.

There were a lot of "maybe"s going around Catra's head but the one thing she decided was a *yes* was the idea of *sitting at the throne*. She had never seen Glimmer herself sit in it, but a fantasy of Catra's, even at the Horde, was being able to sit where a true Royal was supposed to be sitting at. Sure, Hordak's little wannabe throne had been fun to lounge in and taunt him, it made her feel powerful. But *this*. True monarchy, true *power*. She couldn't pass up the chance, even if no one was here to see it since the guards were only ever stationed outside. Another thing that didn't really make sense to her, but oh well.

Carefully making her way up the floating steps, Catra settled into the throne, legs crossed and hands gripping the armrests. It was a bit anticlimactic, in her opinion. The throne was a modest little thing. A rounded foundation with a triangular backrest, but it was *hard* . Even glowing the color of gold the seat wasn't all that comfortable. She could definitely see why Glimmer didn't sit here often, but a new idea came to mind.

"Adora, would you stop worrying? She's probably fine, running around the castle and making a mess, I'm sure," Glimmer had

heard almost an hour of Adora's incessant comments on Catra's wellbeing while they waited for Huntara at the bar, but she was getting tired of it, and so was Bow. Perfuma was in a corner booth, meditating.

Lucky her.

"But she's probably lonely! We left her all alone! Maybe I should call her. Or even better, you could take me back to the castle!" Adora seemed to think Catra would die of boredom if left alone for a day.

Glimmer wasn't convinced. "Adora," she cut off, "we need you here, and Catra has Melog! They'll… I dunno, sense her supposed loneliness and go trotting back to the castle. I'm sure of it! Right Bow?"

Seeing how his girlfriend's expression left no room for arguments, Bow nodded vigorously.

Adora's shoulders slumped slightly, "Can I at least call her? Please?"

The blonde put the best puppy eyes she could muster up and she heard Glimmer sigh in resignation, "Fine, but do it outside. I don't want to hear your sappiness."

Adora smiled in delight and took the communications pad that Bow handed her from his satchel. She practically skipped out of the bar, her now cheery attitude a sharp contrast to the scowls most of the patrons wore. Everyone stared at the blonde, and Glimmer couldn't help but giggle. Adora and Catra really were good for each other.

Right as Adora tapped a few buttons to turn on the comms pad, she heard a beep come from… somewhere. She wasn't as good as Bow when it came to this new tech, and he had installed a bunch of new applications on it. It was all so confusing, but she figured a beep with a blinking red light must mean something important.

Too determined to take it back to Bow, Adora scrolled through a lot of screens and pressed a lot of buttons until she finally found one that made the blinking light stop. It was the cameras inside the castle. Entrapta had installed some for more security and connected them to the pad, saying that they also detected motions and could be programmed to alert someone whenever there was movement in a place no one should be at.

It wasn't perfect, but both Bow and Entrapta had been excited about it, so they were tested out in places like the war room, the throne room, the-

The throne room.

Adora looked at the six screens available only to find her girlfriend sitting in the *throne.* Not only that, but when Adora clicked on the audio button, she realized Catra was *mocking Glimmer* and wearing one of the Queen's capes.

“You! Come here peasant, before I sparkle at your… face!”

Adora gaped at the scene before her, clicking the record button before continuing to listen in.

“I will teleport you over the ocean if you don’t get me some cake right this instant! You! How dare you make fun of the princesses! We’re connected to a rock and have super lame powers!” On the screen, Catra could be seen thrusting her arms forward and making sound effects of what must’ve been Glimmer’s powers with her mouth, “PSHHEEEWWW!”

Catra stood up on the throne and jumped to the bottom of the steps, the cape fluttering behind her as she landed with a “poof” at the bottom which was a horrible imitation of Glimmer’s teleporting, “SPARKLE SPARKLE” she yelled before collapsing on the ground. Soon enough, Catra got up again and took the cape off, replacing the accessory by putting a leaf in her hair.

She looked down at a flower in a small pot and pointed at it, “You! Grow and whack the princess mocker!” She aggressively kicked the tiny flower pot and grabbed a handful of leaves from her pockets, throwing them not very far, and letting them flutter to the floor while she cheered in imaginary victory.

She exaggerated a gasp before yelling out, “It’s the MEGA princess bully,” Catra took the leaf out of her hair and ran to pick up a cup of water from a nearby table, her attitude and

expression changing completely, "Ughh, I'm like, the *least* lame princess. *I'll* handle it," she sloshed the water in the cup a bit before throwing it forward and letting it splash all over the place. Adora could clearly tell it was Mermista, but was surprised at the commentary that came with it.

"It didn't work! I couldn't take out the stupid peasant!" She ran again to the table, this time coming back with a cup full of half-melted ice.

"I'll take it down! I'm Mermista 2.0, cold edition! AAAAAAA," Catra charged at the empty space with as much enthusiasm as Frost would have, heaving the cup down and letting the ice spill out onto the puddle of water she had made earlier. The ice bounced onto her uncovered toes though, and she leaped back with a yelp. "Noooo, I've been taken out by my own ice cream!!"

Catra fell back into the default position she had played the other princesses in, this time, she got into a fighting stance, but it was truly accented by the pincer-motions she was making with her hands, "I'm gonna hug the peasant to death because I *am* the least lame princess!" She charged again, but by the looks of it, the Scorpia imitation had also failed to take out the 'peasant MEGA princess bully'.

Lastly, came the one Adora had been holding in her laugh for, her face nearly red from her silent giggling.

"I'm She-ra! The MEGA lame princess," she went cross-eyed and blew a raspberry.

Not being able to hold back anymore, Adora bursted out in laughter. Apparently though, the audio button made the voice recording available on both sides, and Catra squeaked as she turned to face the direction the camera was in, only serving to send her falling to the ground as she slipped on the flower pot that was rolling around.

"What on Etheria are you doing?" Adora could barely get the words out, still clutching her stomach and wheezing at Catra's performance.

"Adora?" Catra finally seemed to realize how the camera worked, "Uh, nothing! I'm not doing anything…" she shook her head and tried to kick away the mess on the floor, but the camera had a view of nearly the entire room. A blush rose to her cheeks, but she was hoping Adora wouldn't be able to tell through the camera.

The reason Adora couldn't tell though, was not because of the camera but because of the tears in her eyes that were nearly shut as she couldn't stop laughing.

"Adoraaa," Catra whined as her girlfriend didn't stop her wheezing. She sat there on the cold floor of the throne room, impatiently waiting for the dumb blonde to stop laughing. When she finally thought Adora was done, she barely even got through the first syllable of what she was going to say before Adora bursted into laughter again. It happened two more times before Catra finally yelled in frustration, "Adora!"

“Yes, Mega lame princess?”

“That’s you, not me, now stop it!”

“Mhmm. Sure.”

“It is!!”

“You having fun there?”

“...Maybe.”

“What were you doing in there anyway,” Adora was curious as to how Catra’s entertainment had come to be.

Catra hesitated and fumbled with a leaf, “Well, I was just bored and I was gonna catch up on some work before I realized it was empty and clean unlike usual so I just sat on the throne and… yeah.”

“Oh yeah! Glimmer knows a spell that moves the cabinets back to her office whenever she wants to so the throne room is always clean unless she’s in there,” Adora finished with a nod.

Catra gaped, “That little cheater! She *is* messy! She tricked me!”

And with that last sentence, Adora had the best prank idea ever.

Trigger Happy

Chapter Summary

It all goes wrong.

Chapter Notes

To anyone who might care, sorry for the wait but I had to let finals finish kicking my ass first. I have to say though, I "studied" the night before my AP World History test by reading a Cold War AU and it WORKED.

Now, do the power limits and balance between the princesses and a bunch of trigger-happy crimson waste raiders make sense here? No, absolutely not. But I'm not creative enough to come up with any other 'villain' or figure out a way to make it make sense. This is still a little cringy, at least to me, and like half of it doesn't make sense as well as the fact that it has more mistakes than usual because I posted it on my phone.

But it's whatever! (It's not)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Surprisingly, the trip to the Crimson Waste had only lasted till the end of the day, and Glimmer was up for teleporting them back to Brightmoon. Huntara had easily accepted the aid in getting rid of the bots and nearly the entire time was spent trashing prime's technology, only having to occasionally make sure the gangs and raiders stayed in line. After the call with Catra, Adora had returned to the group with a newfound, sort of bubbly energy and she used it all to barrel through bot after bot. So far, everything had gone according to plan and everyone was ready to head home.

Of course, things never went the way they had intended to when it came to the Best friend Squad. Huddled in a group of five, Glimmer was already in the process of teleporting, a faint shimmer enveloping Adora, Bow, Netossa, and Spinnerella. With her back turned, however, she didn't notice the pair of crimson waste criminals that caught the tip of her cape at the last minute. (Her capes really are a hazard).

Even arriving at Brightmoon, the dark of night kept the criminals hidden as they scuttled away to the bushes, barely avoiding Adora's and Netossa's suspicious gaze.

Glimmer sighed, "I'm beat, I won't be alive tomorrow. Adora," she turned to the blonde who was intently staring at some section of the castle, "I feel a little bad, but could you please tell Catra to handle the records on…" she paused, trying to remember the name of the town.

"That place in the Kingdom of Snows? Aylesbury," Adora reminded her.

"Yeah, that one. Wait, how did you know that?"

"Oh, Catra said she did that while we were gone. She was in the throne room when I called her," Adora nearly giggled and gave away the plan, but she held it together.

“Ugh, did she ask about how empty it was?” Glimmer knew she was going to get a scolding from her unofficial advisor about actually keeping her space organized, not just hidden away.

“She did. Said she wanted you to meet her there, actually,” Adora took the opportunity to make sure Glimmer would have to go exactly where they wanted her.

The Queen sighed, “Bow, do you wanna come with or head to bed?”

Bow, who had remained mostly uninterested in the conversation as he tinkered with an arrow, hummed in thought before deciding, “I’ll come. Better to make sure the three of you don’t get riled up about some records at this time of night.”

As much as Glimmer wanted to disagree, she knew that Bow had plenty of reason to believe she and Catra would argue about records of all things. Adora wasn’t the best mediator either.

The three waved goodnight to Spinnerella and Netossa, the couple lucky that they were able to go straight to sleep.

Once again, Glimmer teleported to the center of the throne room with Adora and Bow, only to find the catgirl draped over the throne casually, the sound of her purr filling the room.

"Hey, Sparkles," she smirked, looking down at the now enraged Queen.

"What-"

"I was thinking," Catra sat up on the throne and tapped her claws on the arm of the seat, "You mentioned how I took over the Crimson Waste in under a day. And I wondered, 'Could I do it again?' That's not enough of a *challenge* though, is it? No. But I figured Brightmoon would do," she smirked at the appalled look on Glimmer's face. Not so much on the betrayed look on Bow's though. Adora, however, seemed to be in a trance and it provided momentary entertainment for Catra.

Everyone in the room was in a different state of emotions, but one thing was clear to the Crimson Waste criminals who had been peering in through a window. Boss Catra was back in action, and she had already taken over Brightmoon for them. With one of the few communication pads that Brightmoon Techmaster Bow had so kindly provided the people of the Crimson Waste, one of the men sent a message: Brightmoon has been conquered by ex-Commander Catra of the Horde. Anyone who wants a part of the win, come and pledge loyalty to her.

The tension only lasted a few seconds before Catra burst into laughter, cackles filling the room while Glimmer and Bow stood there, confused. Adora was off in a corner, giggling.

"You should've seen the looks on your faces," Catra fell back into the throne, her squeaky laughs still not stopping.

Glimmer was seething. Here she was, concerned that her friend had actually never been her friend in the first place but wanting to give her the benefit of the doubt, while her other friend was giggling along with what must've been a prank all along. Bow was still wholly confused, but he seemed to have figured out that there was no actual threat and just went back to making sure Adora didn't pass out from her silent laughing. He was tired.

"What the *fuck* is going on???"

Finally, Catra stepped down from the throne, tiny chuckles escaping her mouth, "Adora and I pranked you, Sparkles. It was when she called me on Bow's comm pad."

"No shit, Sherlock," Glimmer flicked a ball of sparkles in Catra's face, just to annoy her, "I just- why this?"

Wiping away at her eyes, Catra muttered a low, "Just because…"

Glimmer didn't buy it. "Would you care to elaborate?"

"No, I would not." Catra humphed and fought off a blush as she looked away, pretending to still rub sparkles out of her vision.

"Adora?"

The blonde turned, oblivious, “Huh?”

“Did you plan this with Catra?”

“Uh, yeah. Why do you ask?” Adora was getting a little suspicious herself, but Catra hadn’t said anything yet.

“How’d you come up with it. I gotta say, it was pretty creative,” Glimmer was laying on the compliments gently. Too much and Adora would notice.

“Oh! Well I saw Catra pretending to-”

“Adora!”

Glimmer smirked. She knew everything she needed. Quickly, she grabbed Bow with his tracker pad and teleported them to their room. She clicked the pad on as Bow got ready for bed. He was way too tired from teaching the crimson waste people how to use his tech. Glimmer could deal with whatever was going on.

The Queen was ready to scroll through all the automated recordings of the throne room camera, but she was pleased to find a video that had been purposefully recorded, audio and all.

Just as she started to watch the video, Catra could be heard outside, the click of her claws on the Brightmoon floors accompanying the thud of Adora's boots.

"Sparkles! Open the damn door!" Glimmer chuckled as Catra's fists banged on the painted wood. "Adora, kick down the door." Glimmer looked up from the video momentarily, slightly concerned that the blonde might actually do it, but the tentative, "Catra…" reassured her that it wouldn't happen.

Even with the commotion outside their room, Bow slept soundly through Glimmer's gasps and giggles as she watched Catra impersonate nearly everyone in the princess alliance. She was just finishing up with Catra's impersonation of Mermista when claws could be heard cutting through the door. She groaned, "Catra," a kick and there was a gaping hole, "you know you're going to have to file a report to pay for that right?"

Catra didn't seem to care, stepping through the hole and snatching the tablet away from Glimmer while the Queen was snickering at the once again lost look in Adora's face. A blush rose on the blonde's cheeks and Glimmer had an idea of what had caused it.

"How far did you get on the video?"

"Far enough."

Catra groaned, "I was bored, okay? You *left* me here all by myself. And I was nice enough to have planned on helping you with your records. Which I noticed, *weren't even there."*

Glimmer winced slightly. Oh, she was in for it now. She only hoped Bow would be able to keep sleeping like he was now.

When morning came, the sound of hundreds of heavy footsteps and guards around the castle yelling is what woke Adora and Catra up.

"What the-" Catra shot up in her and Adora's bed when the door to their room was thrown open. She felt Adora stir awake and tense as well, but when Catra realized who it was at the door, she pulled the covers over the blonde, “Goat Kyle?”

The goat woman from the crimson waste perked up, “Oh hey boss! We’ve been looking for you!”

Catra kept a neutral expression on her face, but she could feel the waves of confusion rolling off of Adora. “Right. Well what’s going on, I… certainly hadn’t expected… this response…”

As visibly confused as Catra was at the moment, goat Kyle hadn’t seemed to notice. “Right? After the Horde fell, and rumors about you joining the Princesses spread, we thought you were done for! But then when you sent that message out, it all made sense!”

“Of course. How many people received the message?”

“Uh, well the old gang all got together for you, and a lot of ‘em convinced some newbies to join too! It was pretty easy, they all said you were one of the best gang leaders around the wastes. Not a softie or a loser like that Huntara or- or Tung Lashor,” goat Kyle faked a laugh, probably hoping to appeal to Catra.

It was difficult to seem happy though, when Catra could hear the guards down the hallway struggle and fail to beat a group of waste criminals. They were outnumbered, and Bow had *just* given the waste people new tech. They probably had some old Horde stun batons too. There weren’t even many princesses around the castle nowadays. Spinerella and Netossa had slept over last night though, and they had Glimmer, Bow, and She-ra. Maybe they’d be able to take down the raiders even with all the guards down.

“How many people have been restrained?”

“Oh! Well the Queen and the guy with her were taken down pretty easily. Can you believe they had a hole in their door? Princesses are crazy right?”

“Haha, right…”

"The other two princesses were a little harder, but Joey and his crew were able to get 'em while they were still asleep and stumbling. The guards were probably the hardest to get since they were up and kicking. We got it handled though, no worries!"

Catra was definitely worried, but it seemed spending some time in the Horde had made Kyle more competent, at least when giving reports, "Great! Just let me get presentable for the group and I'll uh, meet them in the gardens outside. Dismissed."

Goat Kyle finally exited the room, closing the door behind her, and Adora flung the covers off her. "Catra? What the fuck is going on?"

Damn, Catra knew she messed up now. Adora didn't curse very often, but this was definitely up there on the list of times Adora said 'Fuck'.

"I don't know! But they obviously think I turned bad again, or something!"

"Why didn't you let me take them," Adora was confused, angry, worried, and so many other things.

"From what I can tell, they have stun batons and stun guns, Adora. Last I checked, you're not immune to getting electrocuted. We have to play this right. They already have Glimmer, Bow, Netossa, *and* Spinerella. The guards are down too. We're

outnumbered and I don’t think just She-ra can take them this time. It’s too many.”

Adora huffed. She knew Catra was partially right. “She-ra’s more powerful now though. It’s worth a try.”

Catra narrowed her eyes, staring at Adora’s determined expression. The blonde wasn’t going to back down from this one. “Fine. You can go out there, but I won’t be able to help you. If they take you down at least I can still play the part of evil gang leader. You know I hate seeing you hurt though, so you better kick their asses.”

Adora nodded with a grin. Catra was already up and getting dressed, but she had a bad feeling about Adora’s plan. That always happened with Adora’s plans though, so not much had changed with this one.

Adora had not kicked their asses.

Maybe it was because Catra had accidentally sent *everybody* to the gardens, or the fact that the new stun guns these people had were rigged to take down even the strongest of Prime bots (wasn’t Huntara supposed to be regulating who got weapons), or even just that Adora as She-ra wasn’t heavily inclined to just killing people, no matter how ‘evil’ they were.

Either way, by the time Catra made it to the gardens, Adora was in her She-ra form and getting endlessly tazed by discs of

electricity that were sticking to her body. Catra felt a tug at her heart seeing Adora like this, especially since she hadn't been in this much pain since the end of the war. Especially since just a couple years ago, Catra would've gotten some sick pleasure at seeing Adora lose. Catra walked closer, waving her hands in the air as a sign to stop the firing, "Alright, alright. I think you guys got her. Good job." Seeing Adora shrink back to herself, her eyes shut tightly closed, gritting her teeth in pain and her limbs still twitching with aftereffects, Catra wanted to bend down and hold her close. She wanted to whisper a thousand apologies in her ear. She wanted to chew her out for putting herself in danger again because she was a self-sacrificial idiot. But she couldn't.

There were too many people here. And she still had a part to play.

Looking back to the hundreds of crimson waste people that had come to follow her just because of a message she had apparently sent, Catra realized just how much power she could have had if she stayed in the Crimson Waste. For a second, just for a second, Catra let herself feel that greed again. That familiar need to climb the ranks and have complete control.

But the moment was over. Right after that second, she felt disgusted. That was the same type of thinking that she had had back in the Horde her entire life. It was the kind of thinking that had gotten Shadow Weaver dead. She had loving friends now, she had a support system. She had *Adora* . How could she let herself think she would be happier as the leader of some evil group?

Shaking her head, she moved over to Adora. "Great job restraining everyone in the castle. Make yourselves comfortable

while I take this one with the rest." Catra hoped they threw a party or something. They'd be distracted, easier to take down. Once she got everyone else free, they'd be golden.

"Boss!"

Catra turned to face one of the lizardmen who hadn't made their way back into the castle.

"I'll take you to where we tied the rest of 'em up."

Catra hid a grimace, nodding instead. Looks like that wasn't going to happen.

Dragging Adora down the halls in a way that made it look like she didn't care about what hurt the blonde was harder than Catra imagined it to be when she first tugged on Adora's arms in the gardens. Adora was heavy because of all that muscle she kept building up from her post-war workouts and lifting literal buildings as She-ra. Aside from that, Catra winced every time she heard a groan after bumping into every corner they turned.

At some point though, they were nearing one of the spare rooms of the castle Adora groaned again. The lizardman accompanying Catra was apparently annoyed, and when he gave the girl a kick in the ribs, Catra broke. "Hey!" The lizardman startled with Catra's growl, and backed away. Stumbled to find a way to keep her cover, Catra hissed, "Only *I* get to punish the prisoners. *Especially* She-ra. Got it?"

The lizardman nodded eagerly in fear of already getting on the new boss's bad side. With a huff, Catra continued down the hall until she finally reached the place where the other 'prisoners' were.

Inside the room, Catra found an unconscious Glimmer, Bow, Spinerella, and a murderous-looking Netossa. "You can leave now. I have it handled from here."

"But, she's awake Boss, don't you think I should-"

"Are you questioning my ability to handle a *princess* ?"

"I- No, of course not, ma'am."

"Then act like it. You're dismissed." The demeaning and controlling voice she had in the Horde came easily to her, and Catra wondered if she had really changed as much as she thought she had. The lizardman finally left the room, and Catra immediately dropped to her knees, trying to make Adora wake up, "Adora, Adora?" She tapped on the blonde's cheeks and shook her by the shoulders. Finally, Adora's eyes opened with another groan, staring right at Catra's worried face.

"Hah, looks like you were right, 'bout the stun batons," she closed her eyes again and winced with every occasional jolt she still felt.

“God, I’m so sorry Adora, I didn’t think that was going to happen-”

“You did, actually. You warned me and I didn’t listen. This one’s on me, okay?”

“I’m sorry,” Netossa broke into the moment, “WHat the actual fuck, is going on? Explain, people!”

Spinerella woke with a wince, “Darling, if you could keep it down- oh. Why are we tied up in the spare room?”

“I don’t know, ask the only people in here who *aren’t tied up,* ” she glared pointedly at Catra and Adora.

“Uh, somehow a bunch of crimson waste criminals all got together thinking that I was their leader again, and now there’s too many of them and I’ve been pretending to be who they want me to be but I don’t know what to do anymore,” Catra rambled watching the confused faces on both Netossa and Spinerella.

“And why would they think you were their leader again,” Netossa questioned with narrowed eyes.

Catra made her way to Netossa, cutting through the rope that kept her wrists bound, “I have no idea. It just- happened. I woke

up and they had already restrained you guys. I was outnumbered."

Rubbing her wrists, Netossa perked up, "OK, well, now that you're here, you can free us and we'll all take them on-"

"We can't. They have stun guns, the ones you guys gave them yesterday. There's hundreds of them, and they're all trigger happy."

"...I don't see how that overpowers us if we all work together," Netossa was just as determined as Adora had been. Dammit, were all princesses like this?

"If you want to try and take on a bunch of crazy crimson waste people, be my guest, but I can't help you. I need to keep pretending in case the plan fails. And, at least wake up Sparkles and Bow first."

Adora had already been on that, gently shaking Glimmer and Bow's shoulders, but it wasn't working. Catra sighed, inhaling a lungful of air before yelling, "WAKE UP YOU HAVE A MEETING WITH THE MAYOR OF WATFORD IN TEN MINUTES."

Glimmer gasped as her eyes shot open, a panicked expression taking over her face before she saw where she was.

The Mayor of Watford was the annoying and entitled man Catra had ever had the displeasure of meeting. She was lucky she wasn't allowed to attend any meetings, because one encounter when he had been wandering the halls of the castle had been one meeting too many. Glimmer always needed prep time to calm down before meeting with him, but he was adamant about punctuality, and one minute late was atrocious in his mind.

"Why? Why would you do that to me?" Glimmer said it in such a calm voice, it scared Catra a little.

"We need help taking back the castle from crimson waste raiders." Catra laid it out plain and simple. No sugarcoating.

"WHAT?"

"Glimmer, do you have a meeting with that mayor again?" Bow had apparently woken up, but he was still very much out of it.

"No, Bow. Apparently, we rested for five minutes and now the castle is being taken over," Glimmer was close to screaming.

" *Has* been taken over, you mean."

"Not helping, Adora!"

In the end, the group decided they wanted to go and take on the raiders. Catra objected, but it was five against one, Adora having regained her optimism and belief that the power of teamwork would help them win.

It was so princess cliché it physically hurt Catra. But still, she offered her trusty backup plan of staying behind to keep playing the part of evil gang leader.

What they hadn't expected was that there were already dozens of raiders stationed outside the room, their stun guns aimed and ready to fire.

Turns out, the lizardman *had* questioned Catra's ability to handle a princess, and sent two men to help if anything went wrong.

All Catra could think of was that Sparkle's castle needed thicker walls if they could hear entire conversations in a closed room.

The moment the princesses (plus Bow) had burst out of the room, ready to go chase down some criminals, they were barraged with disks that electrocuted them the moment they made contact.

Not even Catra's backup plan had helped them. The raiders had heard everything she said, and she was electrocuted as well. "Ugh, let me go you idiots! It was all part of the plan!"

"We ain't stupid. We know you're lyin'. We don't need ya anyway, we already got the castle."

The two raiders still electrocuting Catra cackled, and it was the last thing she heard before falling unconscious.

"-did they manage this, that's all I want to know!"

"Sparkles, can you shut up," Catra was not fond of waking up to Glimmer's ranting.

"NO. How did these people make a *magic* cell barrier of all things!"

At that, Catra's eyes flashed open. She looked around to find that Glimmer was right. They were all sitting in the same spare room, but this time a light blue column of light kept them trapped. "Well, looks like I actually *did* end up in a Brightmoon cell, just like I predicted."

"Catra!" Adora scolded her girlfriend, but they had more pressing matters, "What now?"

Catra glanced at the two guards in the room, lowering her voice to a whisper, "...I need to get out of here again. My plan can still work, I just need to convince them," She knew it, she knew it could still work, if she was just angry enough… "I need to pretend

to get in a fight with one of you. Throw a couple punches. A few tears. They'll fall for it!" None of them seemed convinced. They all thought it was a bad idea, but Catra wasn't having it, "This is the only chance we might have! If I can contact the rest of the alliance, they might be able to help. But, you all need to act like I'm betraying you, come on, I know you all secretly hate me!"

Catra was thinking of things to say, who to hurt. She knew it would be better if she made it easy for the rest of them, it would be better if she made it *real.*

"Catra, we don't-"

"I made you lose your mom, Sparkles. You can't say you don't have any anger for me there!" Glimmer flinched, but Catra could see the anger simmering right at the surface, "How did it feel seeing me in Angella's throne, huh? I bet I earned that seat more than you have, you never had to *work* for anything, Sparkles."

"Catra…" Bow said it quietly, like he was already hurt by what she had said, but Catra kept going anyway.

Me? I got more power in a day than you have in years," she kept on with her rant, but it was starting to feel a little too emotional, a little too real, "They all pity you, you dont have anyone's *respect* . You keep me here, in the castle all day and have me doing *your* dirty work! You have no respect for the people on the other side of the war."

"Catra!" Adora could tell that the venom in her girlfriend's words wasn't acting anymore, but Catra ignored her, as much as it hurt.

"You think you're all high and mighty just because you were on the 'right' side, but I worked just as hard as you did!" With a pointed claw, she pushed on Glimmer's shoulder, growling.

Glimmer's fists were clenched in anger the entire time, but Catra's claims tipped her over the edge. With a yell, her hands lit up and she shot a beam towards Catra who- even with the space limited by the barrier- dodged it.

"Glimmer!" Bow yelled.

Netossa was ready to restrain both girls with her nets, but Spinerella caught her arm, shooting a pointed look towards the guards in the room who were nearing the barrier. Dammit, Catra's plan was actually working, they would have to let it play out.

"I can take over your pretty pink castle in under a day and you still think you're better than me? I *saved* you from Horde Prime and *I* paid the price for it! Not you! And this is how you repay me," Catra kept running around the barrier, dodging Glimmer's beams of light and leaving the rest of the group to duck for cover, "What? Cat got your tongue?"

Glimmer growled and teleported right in front of Catra, landing a punch to the brunette's face and cutting off her run, "You're lucky

I you’re alive! You’re lucky I let you walk around the castle-around Brightmoon! You should be in a cell just like this, rotting away for what you did! I hate you, I can’t believe I ever called you my friend, I should’ve left you there with Prime, let you be a mindless drone because that’s better than whatever the hell you are right now!” She kept up the punches, but it seemed Catra had given up, or maybe she was just in shock. Glimmer really meant that. Glimmer didn’t know they were supposed to be acting.

An especially strong punch landed on Catra’s cheek, and she was knocked down to the floor where Glimmer gave her a sharp kick to the ribs. "You're gonna regret that," Catra groaned when Glimmer kicked her again before Adora and Bow held the Queen back. Finally, Catra had enough time to pull herself up, still clutching her ribs as she banged on the barrier with a closed fist, "Hey!" The guards who had been watching turned their heads in more interest, "Let me out of here, I don't care if you put me in another room just get me away from this bitch," she growled. The guards looked at each other, it seemed they sensed no harm in doing what Catra wanted. They probably needed to get those two away from each other anyway.

One guard walked out of the room, likely going to call whoever had put up the barrier in the first place. The rest watched intently, and Catra decided to give them a show, "You're going to regret what you did to me," she growled it again, but this time there was a fire in her eyes, one Adora recognized to be right when she was about to pounce on someone.

The cat hybrid flexed her claws, her tail lashing right before she lunged at Glimmer's face, letting the Queen back away some so her claws would only scratch the surface of her nose, just enough to make her bleed but not really hurt her. Adora, Bow, Netossa,

even Spinerella knew that Catra could've easily shredded Glimmer's face in that moment if she wanted to, but Catra was still acting, still pretending.

It seemed Glimmer didn't get the memo.

Chapter End Notes

Some girl broke up with her boyfriend right outside my porch as I was 3k words into this chapter. It took an hour of crying and begging before he finally let go. Don’t worry, the girl was safe, it just tripped me out. It was pretty sad tbh but I’ve never even romantically held hands with anyone so… can’t relate :/ This is why we don’t purposefully fuck up and culture our sleeping schedule to write fanfiction at 1:30 am, people.

ANYWAY, there was a lot more dialogue with this one, and I’m not 100% sure if I love this chapter, but I never do anyway so does it really matter?

The answer is yes. It always matters.

Next update is probably next week, but it could also be in 2 days. Idk, it depends. Thanks for reading!

They're All Sad

Chapter Summary

I basically turned this into an uncompleted character study for these trauma filled bitches lol and there's a lot of cursing too.

Chapter Notes

The fluctuating intelligence and power of these characters, again, does not make sense but this is my story, what I say goes. The characters might be very ooc too but i don't know.

It's a little shorter but it's also earlier than usual though it's still cringy

I wrote this on my I pad this time so maybe it has less errors but still no beta :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had to be dragged out of the cell. When the sorcerer that the crimson waste lackeys had brought to bring down the barrier came, Catra was kicking and screaming, nearly clawing the guards chosen to restrain her.

Catra wished she could say the past half hour had all been an act, but sitting in her new cell, she couldn’t deny that there was a lot of real anger and hurt behind her words. She knew she had made plenty of progress in the past year, with herself, with Adora, with Etheria- but there was always a sense of anger. Catra knew she had anger issues, only fueled by her insecurities and doubts of other people. She was getting *better* . Right?

Melog rarely ever roared at other people, and they directly reflected her emotions. She no longer hissed or snapped as often when people annoyed her. She kept her claws in check.

But she still got angry. She was just getting better at controlling it. Perfuma had told her once that anger was natural, it was an emotion just as prominent as happiness, it was okay to be angry. But Perfuma had also said that behind anger there was often sadness, or a reason to be upset. So why was Catra upset?

The magicat was close to giving herself a headache when she heard a familiar roar in the distance. Melog.

She wondered if they would be able to take on the raiders, or if they would fail just other princesses had.

"Hey! Hey! They're with me," she called out, hoping maybe these knuckleheads would listen to her for once.

The guard in the room turned to face her, skeptically glancing at the snakeman at the end of the hall who was struggling with his buddies, "Then you better get that thing under control, 'fore we put it down like the rest of ya friends."

Catra's brow furrowed in anger at the insinuation that Melog was a simple animal, but kept her cool, "First of all, those rabid princesses aren't my friends, second of all, I have to have direct contact with them," she tilted her head towards Melog, "to get

them to calm down." It was a lie, but even with Melog having grown in size the raiders were already gaining over them.

The guard scoffed, "Ya think I'm stupid?"

"It's true, they respond to me and me only. But they haven't seen me all week, we need to restore the connection."

"How 'bout we just taze 'em and throw 'em in that cell with you?"

Catra growled internally, they were getting the upper hand on Melog already, but she needed out of this cell. "I can still help you fuckers, you know? In fact, you *need* my help. None of you are going to be able to fool the rest of the princesses when they come. Even if they didn't see the message, they come by every week for a stupid tea party," it was actually a sleepover, but details, "who's gonna be able to to take on the water, lighting, flower, tech, *and* ice princess? You caught this batch off guard but you'll be facing some of the most powerful princesses within a couple days. I can make taking them down way easier for you guys."

Catra needed this guy to hurry up with his decision, Melog was dodging a couple stun batons, but the big guns could be heard running down a nearby hallway. He still looked doubtful though. "I know a lot more about the rest of the Brightmoon schedules, records, weapons, resources. Say, where do you guys think King Micah is right now?" Catra knew he was visiting Mystacor for the week, but she knew far too many other things for this guy to reject her offer to help them. If he did, he was just plain stupid,

and she'd have to try at another time even though Melog would be hurt by then.

Growling, the guard called over the sorcerer to bring down Catra's cell barrier, and the moment she was free, she charged over in between Melog and the raiders, placing a palm on their snout for show and calming her own emotions, making them shrink back to their normal size. "Hey buddy," she whispered even knowing that she could've easily said the same in her head, and Melog would have heard it. Like it or not, she missed Melog when they left for their little trips.

She noticed the way the raiders kept near, probably thinking she would betray them, which- she would, but not right now.

"So, you said you were gonna show us what we need," the guard walked up to Catra, and internally, she had hoped he would've forgotten about that, but on the outside, she was smirking like she was going to have the most fun in Etheria exposing the records of the Queen of Brightmoon.

"What is this? You said you were gonna tell us about where to get the good loot!"

Catra sighed at how clueless these raiders were. She was partially glad they wouldn't be able to understand how to order weapons shipments on their own, but having to explain how files worked to these people was like trying to explain how to make a cake to Adora. They wouldn't get it, and a mess would be the end result if they tried it on their own. "This *is* the good stuff. You just have to order it, and it might take some time. We don't have," she

snatched on of the papers out of someone's hand to read off the item, "'reinforced steel custom swords' here in Brightmoon, but we have the money and authority to order them."

"Then why can't we just take the money and go get 'em on our own?"

Again, Catra found herself wanting to strangle someone. Had she been this confused when she first started handling things in the Horde? "You can't do that because the general public is not allowed to just go up to the place and order swords, they come in bulk and are made for militaries of Kingdoms, such as the one you are *standing in* . Understand?"

Based on the slow nods Catra received in response, they did not understand, but there wasn't much else she could do. She had already won over the raider's trust easily again, except for a select few who she assumed were the smarter ones of the group. "Good, now we need to figure out how we're going to deal with the princesses that are going to come," she personally hoped to isolate the first one that came by, asking her to flee and warn the others while Catra got the ones here out.

"Which one is gonna come first?"

Catra glanced down at the schedule she held in her hands of this month's meetings and winced, "The water one, Mermista. Her boyfriend will be close by. She's coming tomorrow for a meeting with the Queen. I can take her though."

One of the Minotaurs narrowed their eyes at her, “Why can’t we take her?”

Catra rolled her eyes, “Your weapons are electricity based. She could just flood the castle with the water from the lake and we’re all toast if one of you sets a stun baton or a stun gun off.”

“So get us weapons from the armory then. We can fight her with swords and spears just fine.”

“The stupid princesses and the Queen didn’t trust me enough to get me a key for that room. For good reason too.” Catra wasn’t about to let these people into the room that held literal cannons.

“We can pick the lock.”

“It’s bolted shut from the inside, we can only get in there if the Queen teleports and opens it,” this guy really didn’t trust her, did he?

“Then we take down a wall.”

“The room is lined with steel,” she growled out, “end of conversation. The princesses is probably itching for a rematch anyway, after what I did to Salineas.”

A new, more enthusiastic raider spoke up, “Oh yeah! I heard about that. Totally destroyed her kingdom. I hear it *still* hasn’t been fixed!”

The group laughed, but Catra could bring herself to put on a fake smile. Mermista still didn’t like her, and she was fine with that, but she was working hard to try and make up for her mistakes. Or as Perfuma preferred to word it, “do good so as to not let the bad define you.”

Catra couldn’t sleep.

She was in her and Adora’s room, but it felt wrong to sleep here while her love was probably worried and stirring like crazy in a cell. She couldn’t even visit her though, there was a nightguard and Catra couldn’t risk getting caught.

Well… she *could* , but the consequences would ruin the whole plan…

She found herself sneaking past the guard in the middle of the night anyway, with Melog cloaking her.

“Adora,” she whispered, hoping the blonde wasn’t asleep too deeply. She was right next to the wall of the barrier too, hiding from the guard who she was pretty sure was snoring and about ready to slump over.

Almost immediately Adora whispered back, her eyes snapping open, “Catra?”

“Hey princess,” she smirked at the blonde’s expression.

“Where have you been?! I’ve been worried all day and I thought-“

Catra quickly shushed her, reminding Adora of the guard in the room, “I’m sorry about that, but the plan worked. They let me out again and tomorrow-“

“What are *you* doing here?” Glimmer and Netossa had woken up from all the whispering, but Glimmer in particular was glaring at Catra with disgust.

“Telling you guys the plan, *Sparkles* ,” she said the nickname with the same demeaning and mocking attitude she had back in the war.

“Oh, so *now* you act like you’re on our side, but just a few hours ago you were ready to claw my face off and take over my kingdom, weren’t you?”

All that progress, all that work put in between the two, was swept away in an instant.

“What? Like you said, it was *acting* , or are you too dumb to understand the concept of that?”

“ It seemed pretty realistic to me, *Horde Scum* , you even had Adora fooled for a second, and she knows you best,” the blonde in question looked away in guilt when Glimmer waved a hand towards her.

Adora could feel Catra’s gaze burning on her. It was true. Adora had lost hope for a second there when Catra was yelling at Glimmer. And it was precisely because of the fact that Adora knew Catra best that she recognized the rage that was sent with every word Catra had spit out.

Catra scoffed, “Did you really think…” she paused when she noticed Adora still hadn’t turned to look at her, “Adora?” When her girlfriend still couldn’t meet her eyes, pausing a second too long before looking up, Catra knew Glimmer hadn’t been lying.

“I…” Adora couldn’t come up with an excuse.

Catra gaped, hurt flashing in her eyes in a moment of vulnerability before she huffed in anger, and a fire replaced the hurt, “You know what, maybe I *should* leave you in there-“

“Catra, please,” Adora begged.

"Fine, only because I'm not willing to go that low. We'll talk about this later, *Princess* ."

Much like Glimmer's nickname, Catra hissed the name 'Princess' in the way she did during the war, and it only added to Adora's guilt.

The rest of the time that Catra was explaining the plan to them, she remained angry, or simply indifferent. By the time she left, Adora still hadn't found any words to explain herself and she watched Catra leave alongside Melog, her tail and ears drooping slightly. Paired with Melog's slightly grey mane, Adora knew she had fucked up, and now Catra was going to think Adora didn't trust her until they had that talk, which she had a feeling wouldn't happen until a few more days.

Stars, how was she going to fix this?

When Mermista finally came by to Brightmoon, it was clear she had no idea about the raiders. Good, it meant she didn't have an army with her and the message saying Catra had turned evil again *hadn't* reached all of Etheria.

She entered through the front entrance like she usually did, but the halls were devoid of any guards and it was enough to send the princess on edge. Something was wrong and she knew it by the way Catra observed her stance change, eyes scanning her environment and putting a hand over a chattering Sea Hawk's mouth.

Catra had to give it to the water princess, she was incredibly observant.

Even without the guards around, Catra had made sure the raiders were not in sight either. They were hiding in the throne room, all of them cramped in there and waiting for Catra's signal in case something went wrong. She hoped none of them came out prematurely, as there had already been same gang members who had doubted her ability to handle a couple princesses before, they would surely do the same now.

She could only hope. Catra waited, watching Mermista stalk quietly down the hallway, probably looking for someone and expecting it to be an enemy from the way she had her hands flexing, a sign that she had some water ready to go and drown a bitch.

Catra sighed as she realized *she* was the bitch in this situation. Finally, Mermista stood right under the archway Catra was sitting on, the shadows hiding her nicely until she dropped right in front of the princess and Sea Hawk.

A shrill scream escaped them both and Catra had to dodge a blast of water shot her way before pouncing on Mermista. The goal here was to get them into another room, so that Catra could explain away from watchful eyes and pointed ears. It was more difficult than she had expected though, with Mermista also falling for Catra's evil act, and Sea Hawk not far behind. The magicat could see the anger behind Mermista's eyes though, damn, and they were so close to getting on decent terms too.

It hurt Catra, that everyone- even her own *girlfriend* could so quickly believe that she would go back to the way she was before. That everything she had done in the past year meant *nothing* to them. But then again, if Catra believed it, why shouldn't everyone else? *Especially* Mermista and Glimmer. She had destroyed Mermista's kingdom, and they hadn't quite reached good terms in the year that had passed anyway. It was realistic that she would be the quickest to believe that Catra would go against them. It was what she argued for in all the princess alliance meetings the first three months that Catra had been in Brightmoon. And Glimmer, stars she had taken Glimmer's *mom* away from her. Catra was in idiot to think they could be friends just like that.

This all rolled through Catra's head as she simultaneously rolled around fighting Mermista. Well, she wasn't doing much fighting, it was mostly dodging and getting a weak punch in as Mermista used the little water she had to shake Catra around, yelling, "What did you do," and Catra could barely respond, only hoping that Mermista would throw her into a door or something so she could get them alone.

After what seemed like an eternity, Sea Hawk managed to kick Catra's stomach and Mermista gave her a gut punch as well, sending her flying across the hallway until she hit Glimmer and Bow's doors, the ones with a gaping hole in them.

Oh well, it was as good as it was going to get.

"Wait," Catra yelled, clutching her stomach and coughing up water. It made Mermista pause as it had been the first word the

girl had spoken since they arrived, "You- you need to leave, warn-" a cough interrupted her, and Sea Hawk moved to give her a few thumps on the back much to his girlfriend's disapproval.

"What are you talking about? What the hell did you do, I know-"

"Raiders, they took over Brightmoon because," Catra turned her head in shame, this really had been the first time she acknowledged the fact that these people were here because of *her* at the end of the day, "because they *thought* I took over." At Mermista's once again enraged face, ready to strike, Catra rushed to explain herself, "But it was fake! I- it was a prank gone wrong and now they think I'm one their side. So- now I need your help to get them out but you need to warn the rest of the princesses to not come until tomorrow. I need to get everyone else here out and you all need to work together to make them leave because they have new weapons and they caught us off guard."

Mermista narrowed her eyes, "I don't believe you," and she summoned more water.

"Please! They have Adora- I can't- You have to trust me," Catra was begging, she didn't think they had fed or given water Adora or the rest of the group since they had been out in the cell, they were going to be starved and Catra was getting desperate now, "just this one time," Catra nearly fell to her knees, ready to Mermista pummel her more until she did what Catra asked, "trust that I don't want anything bad to happen to Adora."

Mermista still looked doubtful, but a sad Sea Hawk put his hand on Mermista's shoulder, and she conceded. "What do you need us to do?"

Catra sighed in relief, she was really starting to be much more external with her emotions, "You need to gather up the rest of the princesses, all of them. They have Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Nerossa, and Spinerella here in a cell so I'll get them out but you need to bring everyone else. Be ready for the stun guns they have. I thought you might be able to take them on alone with your water against the electricity but I wanted to warn you first and we can't have this go wrong, it already did too many times and I want to be extra cautious this time. There hundreds of these guys but I need to keep them fooled." Catra sighed, remembering what she had planned for herself, "You need to get really fucking close to drowning me, enough that they'll think you wanted to kill me"

"That won't be a problem."

"But then you have to let me claw you up a little and when I call for backup you need to act injured and run."

Mermista groaned, "Is it necessary for you to scratch me?"

"It needs to be as real as possible, or they won't trust me, and I think it's a little fair considering how you already attacked me and are about to drown me for a bit."

“Ugh fine, but Sea Hawk,” she addressed the man who had been uncharacteristically quiet this entire time, he beamed at her, “you are *not* allowed to carry me.”

The man pouted but eventually gained back his eagerness, “Fear not, my dear Mermista, for I shall not disappoint and will be ready for tomorrow’s *epic battle* .”

He sounded far too excited in Catra’s opinion, but she gave Mermista a nod anyway, the sensation of water filling her nostrils following immediately.

Mermista had plenty of scratches and blood smeared all over her when the raiders burst out of the throne room, Melog leading them to where Catra was. The princess was already fake limping out of the castle, Sea Hawk also pretending to support her weight with an arm wrapped around his shoulders as they made their way quickly to the exit.

While the raiders gave chase, Melog went to check up on Catra, whose vision was fuzzy and nostrils burned after what she had asked Mermista to do. Aside from several bruises and internal pain however, Catra was mostly fine so she stood up with a little help from Melog.

“You let her go! You said you had her!” The raiders were already complaining, but Catra had prepared for that.

"I didn't *let* her go, she escaped, and you all wouldn't have been much help anyway, she doesn't do hand to hand *or* close quarters combat, so your stun guns only would've made things worse. I called for backup too, you guys let her escape already injured."

Catra knew angering a bunch of criminals with anger issues and no sense of morals was probably very bad, but she couldn't help it, she nearly drowned and people were complaining to *her* .

A few of the criminals grumbled their agreement, and others didn't seem to care. They acted like it wasn't really their problem, probably expecting Catra to do the big stuff for them. "She was scared anyway, she won't be coming back, you saw how she left," Catra tried to convince them, "right now we don't have any other problems, she'll probably go tell her friends to stay away too, we have the numbers, after all."

The raiders cheered, and Catra was relieved to see that even the smartest of the criminals had been fooled. They were lowering their defenses, tomorrow she would let the others out of the cell. She could only hope that Mermista would do her part as well.

Glimmer's stomach rumbled. Nobody, not even the guards had come into their cell to bring anyone any food or water and the past two days. She was pretty sure she recalled Adora telling her once that the body couldn't go without water for three days. Stars, they were so fucked.

Everyone in the cell spent most of their time sleeping, there wasn't much else they could do. Of course, Adora had been the

one to find a different way to spend the time: stewing in her own guilt.

It wasn't like the blonde spoke much, none of them did right now with their dry mouths and throats, but Glimmer could tell by the way Adora simply sat and stared at some random spot, her brows furrowed and every so often a few tears gathering in her eyes, never spilling though. She caught Adora looking like that a few times during the war, always thinking about the next battle plan, what she could do better, who she could've helped, cataloging every injury and every weakness Adora might have seen in herself.

Now though, Glimmer knew for a fact that every thought crossing Adora's mind was about Catra. Internally, Glimmer scoffed, Catra was back to hurting everyone she came into contact with. How dare she? Glimmer had provided Catra with a place to stay, she let her stay with Adora, more importantly, her best friend. Catra really thought she deserved that and more because what? She saved Glimmer's live once? After how many times of nearly killing her?

This time, Glimmer's scoff could be heard in the cell, even as her thoughts were limited to her mind. All because apparently, Glimmer didn't deserve what she had, because she hadn't *worked* for it. As if Glimmer had had such and easy life. She had grown up in and fought in the middle of a war as well, was she just supposed to apologize to Catra because she wasn't traumatized enough for her? *Sorry I'm not traumatized enough to be sad, or angry, sorry I'm not up to your standards for having emotions.*

Stars, and for Catra to insult her *mother.* No, there was no way she was letting her off the hook that easily. She had kept it inside

for a long time, but the longer she thought about it the more true she knew it was. Glimmer hasn't forgiven Catra for what she did, any of it, and if that stupid cat thinks she can just disrespect the Queen and threaten to undermine her power, she’s got another thing coming.

Adora was worried. Not about the emptiness in her stomach or how dry her throat was, but about her and Catra.

This entire year, the both of them had prioritized making time for just *them* even in between all the rebuilding efforts and any threats that showed up. They weren’t perfect, far from it, but they were a little more open, their communication was improving, and they were happier than they ever had been even with any fights they had.

So why had Adora doubted Catra? The blonde was her biggest defender in the area of Catra potentially turning against them. She didn’t defend Catra’s past actions that’s for sure, but she made sure that everyone knew that Catra was doing her best to be a better person *now* .

But then again, this had been a problem before. Catra’s anger. It was still *there* even with all the coping mechanisms and calming techniques Perfuma provided her. They helped, but some days it was more present than others. Adora made sure to let Catra know that was okay though, they all had bad days and even Adora’s anger got the better of her sometimes.

None of it made sense to Adora. Her own actions didn’t make sense and it was so frustrating. Catra gets into one fight with

Glimmer, says a few nasty things, and all of a sudden Adora’s brain decides that Catra is back to her old self, the Catra that’s as ruthless, giving orders to fight and hurt and kill and doing so herself directly even.

Adora still loved Catra though, even when she had doubted her for those minutes that Glimmer was throwing herself at the barrier, cursing Catra and the guards.

What made Adora the most anxious was what Catra was thinking. Adora was supposed to support her through everything, and she had, but now it turns out Adora didn’t actually believe in that, in her. That’s what Adora assumed was going through her girlfriend's head at the moment, if not worse. It only made Adora want to get out of this stupid cell sooner, but she couldn’t. She couldn’t help, she couldn’t fix anything. All she could do was sit and wait while her legs fell numb.

Stars she would kill for some water right now.

Chapter End Notes

Adora has trauma related to Catra.

I know it, you know it. I always tend to ignore it because Catradora but I guess I decided to explore on that a little more starting with this chapter and going onto the next.

The next one might take longer than usual to update because I want to do a little research but I hope you liked this one!

A long ass therapy session

Chapter Summary

Basically the title, except it's only the Glitra friendship therapy session after they defeat the evil criminals yayyy

Chapter Notes

This one might be boring for ya'll so sorry about that. There's really only 1k words of action and the rest is just 4k words of them talking about their feelings, not much else to it but there's a few sprinkles of humorous stuff in there and some Glimbow at the end.

TW for self-harm, nothing super major but it's there

Also, does this mean I need to up the rating? I think I will just in case.

Also, ALSO somebody on TikTok put one of MY WORKS in a video with their fave fanfictions, UNPROMPTED and they put it alongside some TOP TIER fics, it's just- idk I just wanted to be excited for a bit-

ANYWAYS, sorry for the long ass notes both here and at the end you may go read now if you haven't

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was finally time. Even with any anger she might've held towards Glimmer and Adora, Catra was getting the cell open today so that the group would be ready at the same time that Mermista came. She had gotten the sorcerer from the crimson waste on his knees, her claws pressing dents into his neck as he shakily cast a spell to take down the magical barrier. She had five cups of water filled to the brim, but food would have to wait. Nobody had noticed her taking the sorcerer, and the guard in the room was oblivious to

everything happening after Catra had knocked him out. She didn't want to risk anything even with Melog cloaking her.

After everyone had finished desperately gulping down their water, Catra was telling them exactly what to do. "You're going to focus on this back part of the castle. Run any raiders you find out of the rooms, take them out of there or lead them to a section of the castle more in the front. If we can gather them up they'll be tougher to defend against but hopefully with more princesses we'll be able to keep up with them this time. We have to wait here until we see Mermista's signal."

"What does it look like," Bow questioned. It was probably for the best, seeing as how so far she hadn't answered neither Glimmer nor Adora.

A few seconds later, one of Entrapta's new bots stomped over to the castle entrance, the ground rumbling with its arrival. Right on time, "That's the signal, GO!"

Immediately, the group burst out of the room and stormed into another one. Thankfully, Catra had planned for all of this to happen early in the morning. Raiders were still asleep or hungover, so they startled horribly and were unable to gain their bearings before any of the alliance members took them out.

It was all going very smoothly, Catra made sure to have the raiders with access to stun guns at the front of the castle where the rest of the princesses could be heard attacking. As much as the group might not want to admit it, they were weak from a lack

of food and water, even She-ra seemed to be just a bit slower. Catra knew that could prove fatal in combat, thankfully, the blonde wasn't alone like the first time she had attempted an attack on the raiders.

Catra herself ran circles around the criminals, they were so tightly bunched up that knocking one over would cause the other behind them to stumble. If they didn't, Melog would simply finish the job and knock them out. They weren't quite aiming to kill these people, they had been deemed too stupid to really be able to do anything largely threatening without a higher power to rally behind, but if a few of them didn't get up after a particularly hard blow, nobody said anything.

Everyone could hear the screams of panic across the castle though. Frosta was probably doing a number on them, the youngest of the princesses always eager to punch someone. She had gotten bored after the war, her ice fists no longer making any appearances. Catra almost felt bad for the criminals, she knew how much power one of Frosta's punches had.

The fight to take back Brightmoon Castle was over surprisingly quickly. Maybe Catra had gone overboard with the amount of manpower she had requested from Mermista, but after so many previous tries, she was glad she did what she did. The front half of the building was taken in about half an hour, and the back half was taken soon after when Scorpia had come for backup.

Catra heard Glimmer murmur "So many puddles," on the way back to the front of the castle. It was true. There were plants poking out of some cracks in the floor and walls, black scorch marks left

on the walls, and melting icicles hanging from the rafters. To top it all off, the hallways were slippery from Mermista's power.

Each squelch of boots stepping in a mix of water and plants made Catra's ears twitch in discomfort and her feet hated how the water felt in her fur even with the wraps around her feet only serving to soak up more water.

Even with all the distractions and annoyances though, Catra could only think about the situation she had made with her, Glimmer, and Adora. Finally reaching the front of the castle to meet with the rest of the princesses, Catra knew she could no longer ignore it when the Queen stood in front of her, orbs of lights summoned in her hands.

"Woah, hey now Sparkles," Catra backed up a little, her hands in front of her, "I don't think that's a good idea."

The rest of the alliance that had come as backup all had furrowed brows. Catra had helped them, there was no reason for Glimmer to be threatening Catra. Right?

"Why not," the Queen taunted, "you scared of a little glitter? I'm just finishing what you started now that we have time."

Catra scoffed, "Scared? No," Melog, with their shifting red mane and growling at Glimmer, disproved that statement. "I'm just worried that you misunderstood the situation back there. I'm sure

we can clarify some things though," false diplomacy paired with narrowed eyes only served to confuse the people in the castle more.

"Clarify what? That you don't deserve to be here and that I could take you on any day? I thought we were already in agreement about that."

"Ha! You must be slower than I thought because we both know if you didn't have that sparkly magic of yours I could take you down easily, and even with it I could still beat you," Catra was baiting Glimmer and everyone could see it. They could see how easily the princess turned Queen would fall for it as well.

"Well since you seemed so adamant about the fact that my life was so 'fair' before, maybe we can test that out, show you how much I *do* deserve these powers."

There it was. The competitive and spiteful streak in both of the girls that could be channeled in seconds when prompted.

Adora and Bow were incredibly worried about their respective girlfriends, and even worse, Adora felt helpless as Catra didn't seem to be on good terms with her now. That left Bow, Spinnerella, and Netossa to try and figure out how to keep the two girls from killing each other.

Surprisingly, it was Mermista who put a stop to the pairs' incoming fight.

Stepping in front of Catra and Melog, facing Glimmer, she groaned, "Uhh, excuse me? I don't think so. Last I checked, it was *Frosta's* turn to attack Catra. You already got a turn, and I got my turn a couple days ago, you can't just go two times in a row."

Everyone was stunned. Mermista, as nonchalant as she had acted about it, was *defending* Catra, at least for now.

"Um," Perfuma stepped forward tentatively, "I sense some hostility between you two," it was the understatement of the century, but it caught Glimmer and Catra's attention anyway. "Perhaps we can talk this out instead?"

A nervous chuckle of agreement escaped Scorpia, "Yeah! Wouldn't want to damage the castle even more, right Wildcat?" It was a low blow, using Catra's nickname, but the magicat agreed to Perfuma's 'offer', and not wanting to be bested, Glimmer also agreed.

Adora was surprised, though, when Perfuma called her to ask if she wanted to join them. "Uh- I don't know if-"

Bow's hand on her shoulder interrupted the blonde. Even between the dangerous glares and threats between Catra and Glimmer moments before, there was a certain tension in the way Catra and

Adora stayed far from each other. Melog still had a red tinge to their mane, but they kept their distance from Adora as well, the person they were usually constantly purring around when they were together, it made things quite obvious. Everyone was clued in especially when Adora stayed forcefully rooted to her spot when her girlfriend and best friend had been circling each other. The blonde had been restraining herself, but she was nervously wringing her hands and tugging at the ends of her hair while she chewed her lip worriedly.

Adora threw an almost scared- no, *questioning* look at Catra only to receive an eye roll in response. She sighed in resignation before also agreeing to 'talk things out'. This was going to be a *long* talk.

They were sat in a circle in a random room in Plumeria, without Melog, though. The princess leading the group through Plumeria had confessed that they were likely to be a distraction in the session. Catra nearly growled at the particular use of the word 'distraction' to describe Melog, but she also knew that as well as she knew how to manage, or at least conceal her emotions, Melog would be growling and changing all the colors of the damn rainbow if she brought them along. So, she sent them bounding out into the Whispering Woods while the rest of the group headed over to a private therapy room.

Perfuma was facing them all while she waited for the trio to get comfortable in their cushion seats on the floor. It wasn't the usual room Catra was in when she and Perfuma had their sessions, but it was close enough with the general plant aesthetic it had even while mostly empty. She shouldn't have expected much more from being in the flower princesses kingdom.

"Alright, Adora if you don't mind, I'm going to start with the conflict between Catra and Glimmer."

Adora nodded in response to Perfuma's gentle request. It was probably for the best, as impatient as Adora was, seeing as how the two other girls in the room had been ready to go to blows.

"Great," Perfuma clapped her hands together before asking, "so, what exactly happened? I'm going to ask Glimmer to tell me first, and then Catra. But please, no interruptions even if you feel the other person might be wrong," she ended with a smile.

Glimmer looked a little too smug about that in Catra's opinion, but she kept quiet anyway as Glimmer recounted how the fight had started.

"Well, we were in the cell, all of us, and Catra started talking about how she was going to get out again, but she just got angry all of a sudden. One second she's convincing Adora of letting her fight me, and then she starts talking about my *mom* of all things, accusing me of being angry, so what if I am?!"

Glimmer was getting riled up again, and Catra was digging her claws into her palms, but Perfuma ushered her to continue calmly. "She's saying that I don't deserve the throne, or my powers because apparently, *I didn't work for any of it* ," Glimmer is practically growling, and her hands are waving angrily in the air, but she keeps going, "I don't have anyone's respect, and she complains that I give her work to do now, as if she didn't nearly kill us all in the war, as if her 'hard work' didn't nearly *destroy*

Etheria, " sitting next to Glimmer, who is fuming, Catra chuckles dryly, and when Perfuma sees blood trickling down Catra's hand, she stops Glimmer's rant.

"Okay, thank you I think I've… gathered enough information from your perspective, Glimmer." Perfuma then turned to face Catra, ignoring Glimmer's muttered *"yeah, my* perspective *"*

"Now Catra, if you could allow me to bandage your hands, we can continue with your side of the conflict."

With a grumble, Catra unclenched her fists and stretched her hands out palm up to Perfuma who was ready with a roll of bandages at her side. Glimmer watched with what seemed to be indifference, but no one could really tell, and Adora was concerned on the sidelines. She knew sometimes Catra hurt herself with her claws, whether it be on purpose or not, but she hadn't seen it happen in a while.

Finally, Catra pulled her bandaged hands back and with a reassuring nod from Perfuma, started telling her own version of the conflict. "We were in the cell, and I had a plan to get out, but we needed to convince the guards to do so. I wanted them to think I was on their side again, so I needed to go against a princess, and who better than her," she waved a hand at Glimmer, who was glaring but didn't say a word, "it was her castle I supposedly conquered anyway. I needed to get into a fight, but since nobody wanted to do that, I took matters into my own hands."

Perfuma nodded, “And what do you mean by that? Was everyone aware that you were doing so?”

Catra rolled her eyes, “Well apparently not because when I started yelling at Sparkles over here she took the things I said to heart. It was fake. It was acting. Even if only one of us actually wanted to do it. So yeah, I said some mean stuff to get Glimmer to yell back at least, but she went a step further and attacked me,” Glimmer guffawed in protest but Perfuma shushed her with a calming hand motion, “and I didn’t even really defend myself. But she took it too far when she said she wished I was still stuck with Horde Prime, or in a cell, or dead, or-“

“Okay,” Perfuma cut her off, drawing the word out, “I think I have a better understanding now. There is a lot going on but we are going to start off with what led to the conflict. Anger.”

Both girls hummed, they couldn’t disagree with that assessment, it was anger that had pushed the both of them over the edge anyway.

“So Catra, your first plan to get out of the cell was in short terms, violence. Were you scared when you were in the cell?”

Catra glanced at Glimmer, tempted to lie but- “Yeah. I… uh… I saw what they had done to Adora earlier, and then later what they did to all of us. I was worried.”

“And would you say you felt the situation was completely out of your control?”

Catra scoffed this time, “Duh, we were trapped, in a cell, with a bunch of lunatics waiting outside and around the castle.”

Perfuma then turned to face Glimmer, “And what about you? Were you scared or concerned as well?”

Glimmer nodded, her gaze avoiding Catra’s but confirming her fears nonetheless.

“Thank you both, I know how difficult it can be to admit your fear, you have all improved greatly in that sector. However, the next step is something that all three of you may not like. We will be discussing things that we have discussed alone, in individual sessions. You can say no, either now or at any time that something is to be revealed about yourselves, but it will make the process much smoother. Do I have your permission to discuss such topics?”

Begrudgingly, they all nodded their heads in approval and Perfuma smiled again, repeating the reminder that they can back out whenever they felt like it. “Fantastic! Now, you are all aware that you have PTSD, correct?”

Cringing slightly at the blunt reminder, the trio nodded.

"Yes this is something I've discussed with the three of you but I think now is a good time to really explain it, seeing as how it hadn't been the focus of the session for any of you when I brought it up." Perfuma was still giving a reassuring smile to the group, but Adora was looking at her with wide eyes, like she was ready to take notes on anything said. Glimmer looked nervous because if Perfuma recalled correctly, she had completely ignored her diagnosis, and Catra was picking at her bandage, acting almost bored but from the twitches of her ears she was listening just as well as the others.

Well, she couldn't really ask for more.

"Alright well when you have PTSD, you are constantly in a fight or flight mode. Because of this, anger is a very common symptom, and that can lead to violence such as it did with you two."

"I chose violence because it was the smart choice, not because I was scared," Catra argued, she didn't see how any of this was really connected.

"Ah, but both you and Glimmer just confirmed that link between your actions and the PTSD. You see, you, Catra, had been triggered by the sense of loss of control. Glimmer, you were triggered by the threat that Catra posed once again. Now, that does not justify the actions you took or the things you both said, but it does provide an explanation. Now, we can move on to more specific aspects of this."

"What?! *More* aspects? I thought we just covered the most important parts," Glimmer questioned impatiently.

Perfuma pursed her lips, and everyone in the room immediately recognized it as her scolding, *You need to be patient with the process* look.

With a sigh, Glimmer settled down. This was going to be a long session, if she could stand to sit next to Catra much longer.

Scorpia stood awkwardly in the hallway with the rest of the princess alliance members after Perfuma and the therapy trio had left. "So… what are we going to do with everyone," she gestured to all the unconscious (or worse) raiders littering the castle.

"Ughh, I guess, it's kind of our job to… restrain them, help the guards they took out, and uh… wait for Glimmer to come back and decide what to do with them…" Mermista waited for any contradictions, and naturally, there were none except for-

"I say we use them as punching bags for now!"

-Frosta.

"We can put them on a boat and light them on fire!"

“No, Seahawk, we can’t.”

“Ooooh, what if I used them for this new experiment Hordaka and I want to-“

“No! We are not doing *any* of those things.” Mermista sighed, as it seemed she was the most responsible person here, other than Bow, of course, who was already in another room untying the Brightmoon guards. “Just- do what I said. Got it?”

Nods and hums of understanding flooded the hallway before the group spread out to do their own thing. How unfortunate that Mermista and Bow didn’t have more pairs of eyes to be able to supervise.

Adora, unlike the other two girls receiving advice from Perfuma, did not think this session was dragging on. In fact, she found it most useful. Useful because everything Perfuma said would be able to help her understand how Catra’s mind work, and therefore how to help her, or if she even could. She knew sometimes Catra couldn’t, or simply didn’t want to be helped in the moment, so Adora had to learn that she couldn’t fix everything, she just needed to give her love her space.

She latched onto every word Perfuma said about “constructive and deconstructive anger”, how both Catra and Glimmer needed to acknowledge their anger more often in order to keep it constructive, and why bottling in their anger is what had led to their respective hurtful words.

Something that stuck with her in particular though, was what Perfuma had told Catra and Glimmer a few minutes ago. She simply couldn't keep it off her mind. It was an apology, "I was too focused on managing your constructive anger and put aside the fact that you *will* have deconstructive anger simply because you had shown progress on addressing your emotions. Forgive me for that."

There was so much talk about anger, revolving around two of the most important people in her life, and Adora hadn't really seen it. Based on what Perfuma was saying, they were bottling it up, and it broke Adora. How had she missed this? Why didn't she know? She should've been paying more attention.

"Adora?"

The blonde shook her head, removing her gaze from a random spot on the wall only to face a concerned Catra and Glimmer.

"Oh, uh, I'm sorry I wasn't paying attention," she licked her lips in nervousness while Perfuma began speaking again.

"Adora, you do realize none of this is your fault, correct?"

You're not a burden, you're not a burden, you're not- "Well, kind of?" She grimaced slightly at the confession. Perfuma had said she needed to say when she was feeling a certain way.

“Could you clarify, please?”

The attention was on her now, and she wasn’t a fan, “I wouldn’t want to interrupt…”

“Just spit it out, Adora,” Catra sighed. She was still a little mad at Adora, but she cared about her girlfriend, sue her.

“I mean, it’s just that you guys were just keeping your feelings all closed up, and I didn’t know you were feeling this way, I didn’t know and I couldn’t help and I should’ve just been there *more* for the both of you and-“

“Oh this is perfect,” Perfuma interrupted Adora’s rant with a clap of her hands before realizing that both Glimmer and Catra were looking at her like she had committed a war crime. “Forgive me, I know how that sounded. It’s simply that with the conflict being nearly resolved between the two of you-“

“When did that happen,” thought Adora.

“ -I wanted to move onto the topic of helping each other. However, Adora, there is something called compassion fatigue that I feel is something I would like to discuss after I finish with these two.”

A shaky nod from Adora, and Perfuma turned back to a still concerned Glimmer and Catra.

"Now that you've both realized the underlying and false meanings behind what you both said to each other, we can move onto forgiveness. Now, remember, forgiveness-"

"'-Is something done for yourself, not for the sake of the other person, and is never forced upon you by me,' yeah, yeah," both Catra and Glimmer finished the now familiar phrase simultaneously. Surprised, they both turned to look at one another and burst into a fit of giggles while looking at Perfuma, who was a bit exasperated with the girls.

"Yes, that is correct, thank you very much. Would you like me to guide you through apologies or do you think you can do it alone?"

"Nah," Catra shook her head, "I'm a pro at this by now." Not really something to brag about, but when it came to Catra it could be said by anyone that that was indeed a very good accomplishment.

Glimmer hummed her agreement, and let Catra start her apology. "Glimmer, I'm sorry for acting the way I did with you and saying things about you that I knew would hurt. They aren't true… I hold you in a very… high regard in terms of trust and respect. I realize that I made you feel upset even if it was kind of my intention at the moment, but I see now that was wrong. You're a great leader, and I think you're way too nice for letting me into your home. Thank you for that. And honestly, I can't image anyone else wielding your sparkle powers." At the end of it, Catra was blushing

slightly and she threw a questioning smile at Perfuma, looking for approval of the apology. She stuck to the script mostly, but it was genuine nonetheless, and Perfuma nodded in encouragement.

Turning back to Glimmer, Catra found a slight smile blooming on the Queen's face, and the magicat received a gentle, "Thanks Catra, I accept your apology and, I'm sorry too. I was angry in that cell and what you said was wrong, but I shouldn't have reacted the way I did. You already know how I feel about my mom, you were a different person when that happened, and I don't forgive the old you for that but that doesn't mean I don't want you as a friend *now* . You've helped me a lot and you have never deserved what I said about Horde Prime, I know that's a sensitive topic and I'm really sorry about that. Plus, you're pretty tough yourself. I don't know that many people who can keep up with us princesses and you're hard to beat in a fight," Glimmer knew she was inflating Catra's ego a bit, but it was true, "Can you forgive me?"

It was a bit out of character for the girls, and they were blushing like crazy, but Catra nodded yes and Glimmer immediately teleported to her side to crush her in a hug with a kiss to the cheek. Adora was in her little corner, crying, and Perfuma was dabbing at her tears with a tissue. "Oh wonderful! I'm so happy you two worked things out! Now remember, there *will* be days where you are simply angry, it can be triggered by anything really, and that's okay, but I will be discussing more coping mechanisms with the both of you in individual sessions," it was a smart decision, Perfuma thought, since Glimmer and Catra were still hugging- well, more like Glimmer was crushing Catra in her embrace, but they weren't really paying attention to her anyway.

After a while, Glimmer pulled away and beamed at Catra before glancing at Adora, who was still sniffling. With a look at Perfuma and a nod, Glimmer gave her thanks to Perfuma before poofing out of the room with a quick, “That’s my cue!”

It left the place feeling a little emptier, Glimmer’s energy leaving a gap of glitter in the room.

Catra was still in a decent mood from her bonding time with Glimmer, but Adora immediately tensed, sensing that it was her turn to figure out her problems. Stars, that was always so much work.

The lingering smile on Catra’s face told Adora it would be worth it though.

“I’m back!” Glimmer yelled while teleporting into the hallway she had left from originally, only to find it was empty.

She frowned slightly before choosing to wander around for a bit, the frown only deepening when she finally reached a room where there seemed to be a lot of commotion inside. It was the common room, and Glimmer pushed open the doors to face the chaos.

“-AIT FOR HER TO GET BACK.” Frosta was the loudest in the room, Glimmer immediately noticed, but she couldn’t really tell who was saying what.

“We could literally just dump them back in the crimson waste.”

“No, we can’t just dump them all on Huntara.”

“WHY NOT? THEY’RE HER PEOPLE, HER PROBLEM.”

“Could you tone it down a bit?”

“NO.”

“That’s very immature of you.”

“Look, maybe if we just called King Micah-“

“He’s on vacation.”

“We could call Hordak-“

“That is the worst idea you’ve ever had, Entrapta, and you’ve had some pretty bad ones.”

“IT'S GETTING PAST MY BEDTIME. JUST SAYIN’”

Dang, how late was it? Glimmer looked out the window before realizing that Frosta was lying, it was still bright out.

"Guys, guys!" She yelled a bit before Spinerella finally noticed her and shushed everyone else. " *What* is going on!?"

Bow had the decency to look sheepish as he answered his girlfriend, "We don't know what to do with the raiders, and we thought you would take too long."

With a sigh, Glimmer started to come up with a plan. Dealing with her feelings was tiring enough, and now she had to do this? She was tempted to just dump the criminals in the crimson waste like she had heard being suggested, but they would probably just become a problem in the future. And she did *not* need that. "What if we set up a virtual meeting with Huntara? It's still early, and she's probably wondering what the hell happened to a good chunk of her population."

Thankfully, everyone, even Frosta, nodded their agreement, and they moved to the meeting room, leaving Seahawk and Frosta to guard the restrained people.

"So we will be confiscating the weapons momentarily, and you get to decide what the punishment is as long as it's appropriate according to the terms we've presented." Glimmer had been decently diplomatic with Huntara, her energy wilting but staying determined to see this through. It had been a long week and she was *tired* of these criminals being in her home.

“Look, I can agree to the weapons thing, it was honestly probably a mistake in the first place to let these fuckers run around with high-powered guns considering who they are,” Huntara spoke despite Glimmer’s muttered, *“Ya think?”* and Mermista’s hum of agreement on the side, “but we *are* still a mostly lawless place. There’s not really much I can do. Not all of these people were from my gang.”

Glimmer inhaled slowly, trying to find the patience inside her to not snap, Bows hand on her back rubbing soothing circles helping slightly, “Huntara,” she spoke calmly, “I have, I can, and I *will* go over there and smack you on the head. I don’t *care* how tough you are, figure something out before I head over there and do something nobody’s going to like. Got it?” She was speaking through clenched teeth by the end of it, but it got the message through.

Huntara knew how much of a menace the tiny, sparkly girl could be. She was a package of chaos disguised in layers of pretty pink and purple shimmer. With a gruff snort, Hunatara smiled, “I suppose there’s going to be a team needed to be sent out now that we don’t have the weapons to use against the Prime bots. I think I know who could be sent on the front lines.”

“Good, we have an agreement. That’ll be all, I’ll be teleporting half of them today and the other half tomorrow.”

“I’ll be there. Have a nice day, Glitter.”

Huntara logged off the comms pad before she could hear the Queen's irritated protests of, "It's *Glimmer.* GLIMMER. IT'S NOT THAT HARD-"

"Okay, why don't we go prep the raiders for teleportation, babe," Bow tried to calm his girlfriend down to no avail.

"She *knows* it's GLIMMER, it's been *years*- "

The archer sighed, "I think you guys can go home now if you want, this shouldn't take too long, and Adora and Catra will be back by nighttime to keep an eye on the raiders. Thanks for the help," he smiled and waved goodbye to those who left as he led Glimmer to the kitchens to get a snack first. He turned to Glimmer again, stopping her rant, "Glimmer?"

"Yeah?"

"Wanna tell me how it went with Catra?"

"Oh yeah! Before I forget, Perfuma said she wanted us to go to a session together to discuss something-"

Effectively distracted, Glimmer went back to her excited self, and Bow smiled as she subconsciously reached for the sandwiches he placed in front of her.

Stars, he was so in love with her.

Chapter End Notes

**warning, this is a VERY long note.

"Now, you are all aware that you have PTSD, correct?" Damn Perfuma chill with the casualness of it. Jeez, can't you tell they're emotionally constipated and don't like acknowledging it even though it's fine since they're coping?

I'm pretty sure it's canon that they all have PTSD or at least Adora and Catra but they all went through some shit and their trauma is still affecting them in the long term so… yeah they all have it, and yes, I am aware having trauma is not the same as developing PTSD.

Catradora therapy session next chapter.

** I do want to say that I did a good amount of research on PTSD, how to manage it, symptoms, triggers, and coping mechanisms for this. I'm not 100% sure if everything in here is accurate but all my sources had the same or very similar information so it's as accurate as it can get from google, and anything Perfuma gives advice on or even says in general might be a quote from a website, not deliberately but from my notes there's bound to be at least a couple phrases. If anyone wants the links just ask and I'll put it in the comments.

I don't know how consistent I'll be able to update from now on because of stuff, but there's a couple loose ends that I think are going to make this work stretch out into just a few more chapters of feelings upon feelings. I hope to be able to make the next update though. Thanks for reading!

They're All Hypocrites

Chapter Summary

Adora finally gets to talk things out with Catra, and they address a couple of problems together. **TW** for Self Harm which is much more heavily mentioned in this chapter than in the last one as well as in the author's notes.

Chapter Notes

*TW** Mentions of self-harm, I cannot stress this enough, it was shown to happen in the last chapter but it is really discussed more heavily in this one.**

Also, super long notes:
“I did have an updating schedule,” I said, “it was around 4 to 5 am in my timezone on Saturday morning,” I said, “just maybe I'll be able to make the deadline,” I said. I WAS WRONG, OKAY. I KNOW, I’M LATE. like- months late. I know this isn't a super riveting story and it probably doesn't matter too much but STILL, I AM VERY SORRY. I let y'all know in the last update but I didn't expect to have taken this long.

Explanation here, if you want it (or you can just go read now): Okay, there are several reasons as to why it took me so long to finish this.

One, I had to do research. My writing might be shit but I don't want to write a bunch of bs on such sensitive topics. I want people to learn just a little bit. I am not a professional though, everything I mention is really only Google-accurate, and I wouldn't actually know if it would help a person struggling with the things mentioned here. BUT, I do the research, and I provide links because if someone DOES want to know, I would rather it be something mildly correct. Your source of information probably shouldn't be fanfiction

anyway, but if it is, then I don't want to give the wrong information.

Two, I have summer school. If you've read some of my previous works, you would know I only write, research, post, etc., in the middle of the night, from around midnight to 5 am, or as long as I can. I treat this thing like a whole ass part-time job because I'm a tryhard in everything I do so if I start to research, it's going to be from the definition of whatever it is I'm looking for, to why it happens, to who it happens to, to everything I can find until I limit myself. Aside from that, I take notes from this research. This takes a long time, time I no longer had because I had to wake up early for school every day.

Three, my school fucked up my schedule. So, I had to wait for about two weeks for them to get back to me and I'm the type of person who can't do one thing before completing the other. So the order of my list to do things was 1. Fix school stuff 2. Start Research 3. Start writing Obviously, that did not happen for a while.

Four, I was just not having the best weeks. I'm a pretty emotional person, so when I have a bad day it usually turns into a bad week because I'm in a bad mood, then everyone around me is in a bad mood, and it's just an endless cycle where I'm on the edge of crying 24/7. Because of this, I refrained from doing research on SH because… well I think it's kind of obvious.

Partially because of these reasons, this is the last chapter, and it's not as long as usual but I think I struggled with not getting it to sound too 'sterile' (those are the vibes I feel like it gives off in some parts) and I want to move on to other works for which I got the ideas for at 1 am. IF you cannot read this because of the TW and you maybe still want to sort of finish this, there will be a line in bold towards the end and you may start reading there.

ANYWAY, thank you for listening to my little vent, you may go read now if you haven't, and remember the **TW** at the top :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Perfuma had situated the couple into a position closer and more comfortable than the awkward distance that Adora had kept from Catra. Their knees were slightly touching in the criss-cross applesauce form they were sitting in, but Adora couldn't help but tense at the contact. She felt that perhaps she was making Catra uncomfortable, after all, they were here because Catra thought Adora didn't trust her, it only made sense that Catra would reciprocate the sentiment.

"Very well, let's get started, shall we? I've already heard Catra's account of the situation, but I would like to hear yours, Adora. Especially how you felt during it."

The blonde's face contorted into confusion, one that Perfuma took note of. Catra, meanwhile, seemed to be looking anywhere but at Adora. "How I felt?"

"Yes," replied Perfuma, "were you scared? Perhaps confused. There is no wrong answer, so please, don't keep anything to yourself."

“Ok, well, I didn’t really agree with Catra’s plan, but then she got started and I knew she was going to go through with it anyway. I didn’t know exactly what she was going to do, so I guess that added to… the shock, I felt. I mean, I knew it wasn’t real, I- I knew she didn’t mean it, I knew that, it’s just-“ Adora gulped, she glanced at Catra with tears welling up in her eyes, a silent apology already present even staring at Catra’s mask of indifference. She looked back at Perfuma, her voice lowered to almost a whisper in what seemed like shame, “I got scared. Seeing her like that again. She was yelling and, it seemed too real, the anger,” she shrugged, “maybe it was real, and I guess I knew that. But I thought we were doing so well, it was really unexpected. Even seeing how she avoided hurting Glimmer,” she hung her head and pressed her forehead into the heels of her palms, “it felt like we were back in the war, and I guess I kind of got stuck with that thought, even when she was taken out of the cell.”

“Adora,” Perfuma started gently, “did you have a flashback in the cell?”

A grumble came from Adora’s hidden face, but with a little more pressing, Perfuma received a nod. If Adora had looked towards Catra for just a second, she would have seen the weak mask of indifference finally crack, showing just how worried her girlfriend was. She might have even felt the soft touch of Catra’s hand coming to lay on her arm, but the magicat pulled away at the last second.

“Thank you for telling me Adora, was it a specific one? Did it trigger anything more?”

“I don't really know, I just remember seeing them get angry, and suddenly I was back in the Whispering Woods, one of the times we came across Catra early in the war, nothing really monumental but, I guess Catra had been in a bad mood that week,” she chuckled bitterly, remembering how Catra, back then still with the Horde, had taken to insulting the entire Best Friend Squad and their backup that day, “the entire time we fought, she was probably yelling more than she was actually trying to get a hit in on us. But Glimmer still got hurt anyway. It wasn’t even that bad! I don’t understand- it doesn’t make sense that I would get a flashback to- to that!” Adora was nearly hysterical, her laugh filling the room and her hands waving around in measure of her confusion.

It was unsettling to Catra, while she had seen her fair share of Adora’s breakdowns, it never failed to tug at her entire being, this way in which Adora was brushing everything off and not letting herself truly feel even while tears actively streamed down her face.

“It doesn’t, it doesn’t make sense,” she sobbed, hiding her face in her hands while Perfuma watched with patience and concern.

“Trauma never really makes sense Adora, we can’t really control that… that way in which our brain chooses to classify things,” Perfuma finished and pursed her lips, brows furrowed in a sort of self-anger like she was upset that she couldn’t do anything to change that.

Having calmed down slightly, Adora looked up and wiped away her tears after a few minutes. Catra watched on silently the entire time, wanting to wipe away the tears herself but keeping her head down. They were focusing on Adora right now, and based on what the blonde had just said, any attempts at comfort from Catra wouldn't help.

"'m sorry about that…"

"Adora," Perfuma said in a slightly reprimanding tone.

"Right, right, I don't have to apologize. My feelings are valid," the girl reassured Perfuma that she understood.

"Good, now back to your flashback. Did it also trigger a panic attack?"

Adora nearly scoffed, she knew her flashbacks nearly always did, Perfuma knew it too, but she always asked anyway, "Yeah, it did."

"Did anyone help you? At least with the aftermath of it, since it seems like everyone was quite busy or distraught when in the cell."

"Bow did. Well, he noticed it first, but he was busy trying to help Glimmer so he got Netossa and Spinnerella to help me calm down. It was after that that I," Adora stopped, glancing at a still

worried Catra and trying to find a way to word her actions in a way that didn't give away the doubt she had had in Catra in that brief moment. "Well I kind of spiraled, and I just kept thinking about the fight, Glimmer was still furious, I hadn't even caught where they took Catra! So, I guess that's when I started to worry. I felt helpless. I was stuck in that cell while everyone else was in danger, and after seeing Catra so angry… I wondered if maybe Glimmer went too far and Catra would be too upset to…" She didn't finish her sentence, it was clear she had been thinking that Catra wouldn't get them out, "Glimmer noticed, obviously, but I had just lost hope for a second, is all."

Adora was fiddling with her fingers, avoiding Catra's gaze. Catra wasn't angry though, not anymore. She hadn't been angry for a while, but Adora's refusal to look at her girlfriend for more than a second made it so the dummy didn't know that.

With Perfuma's lack of comments, Catra took it as the go-to signal to try and take this into her own hands. "Adora, look at me, please?"

Reluctantly, Adora turned her head to stare right into Catra's eyes. The blonde still had tears welled up, and she was anxiously waiting for Catra to say something. She knew Catra wouldn't hurt her purposefully, not again. She knew that but it was hard to believe it sometimes. Catra looked calm though. That was good.

"I'm not mad," was the first thing she said, as if she could read Adora's mind, "I'm not mad at anyone right now, *especially* not you." She turned her head in shame for a moment, but was determined to look Adora in the eyes, "I've hurt you. A lot. I hurt your- *our* friends. For years," she shook her head when Adora

opened her mouth to interrupt and deny it or reassure her, "It's true and it still affects you. I know you don't tell me about the nightmares when they're about me. I know that. But it's *okay* Adora. You can't control how you feel, and if you could," she joked lightly, "it probably wouldn't be the healthiest thing when it comes to you."

"But I don't want to be scared of you Catra- I love you, I shouldn't be scared of you, I hate it," Adora cried.

"I know, Adora," Catra reached for Adora's hands and gently pulled the blonde closer, "I know you love me, but can you really say that you were never scared of me during the war when we fought and I went all in. Can you say you were never scared of me then?"

Desperately, Adora scrambled for a good answer, but there was none. "No, I can't say that because- sometimes we did go too far, but-"

"No buts, Adora. You were scared. Sometimes I was scared too. But I don't think you love me any less because of that. I sure as hell don't. Besides, you're not scared of me now, right? Not when our day is normal and there isn't anything threatening us?"

"No! Of course not, I know you don't do those things anymore, you just slip sometimes but that's okay-"

“Then why isn’t it okay for you to slip?”

“...What?”

Adora looked at her girlfriend with genuine confusion. What had happened with Adora wasn’t a *slip* -

“Perfuma,” Catra started with a tilt towards the other blonde in the room who had been watching them intently, waiting to correct anything that might’ve been said, “said that our PTSD symptoms like anger and fear can be triggered by a sense of loss of control. We were in fight or flight mode, Adora. It’s just that I chose to fight, and you chose something closer to flight, not that you could run anywhere. So you froze up. Pair that with your flashback, I’d say that your fear is completely rational. I didn’t think about that when I was upset. I’m sorry about that.”

Adora sniffled, “...I can't believe you actually remembered everything she said.”

Catra squawked in playful indignation, “What do you mean!? I pay *very* good attention when it comes to Perfuma’s oh so eternal wisdom. Right, Perfuma?”

The couple turned to look at a once again smiling Perfuma, “Yes, Catra, you have proven that several times. You both did well, though, there *is* something I would like to address here. I fear

neither of you will like it but I want the idea of it to be present anyway.”

Adora and Catra glanced at each other nervously, subconsciously scooting even closer to each other.

“I know you two may not want to hear it, but a possibility could be... taking a break.”

“A break? Like from what, interacting with Sparkles when she’s mad,” Catra joked, waiting for clarification.

Perfuma had her lips pursed, she had an idea of what to expect when she said what she did. “No, from each other.”

“Excuse me?”

“What?!”

Adora was visibly appalled at the suggestion that she and Catra should ‘break up’, as she viewed it. From Catra’s now fluffier tail and bristled fur, she thought the same thing. It was as expected.

Quickly, Perfuma brushed the idea away, coming up with a better solution to the couples’ coping, “Hmm, alright then, but I do want

to have more of these joint sessions then, to keep track of how you're both doing, and give you modified and more custom advice on how to help each other. You both need to take care of yourselves before you can truly help each other. I'm not trying to limit you, I simply don't want either of you falling into compassion fatigue."

"Yeah, you mentioned that before, what is that?" Adora leaned forward in curiosity, and though Catra was less outward about it, she too wanted to know what Perfuma's big deal with the term was.

"Compassion fatigue is the sudden appearance of chronic physical or emotional exhaustion because-- like it's name says- you failed to prioritize yourself before helping someone else with their own problems. It's compared to 'burnout' often, but it is not something that appears gradually over time. That's why I said it was sudden." She checked on the couple to make sure they understood before continuing, "mixed with the fact that *both* of you have plenty of baggage, it could cause more problems than usual. That is why I suggested that… 'thing' earlier," she explained. Perfuma had also been focusing on Adora slightly more when she said some things. Catra was in just as much danger of potentially getting symptoms as well, though.

"I want to teach both of you how to prevent this by giving you more coping mechanisms, techniques, etcetera. First things first, how you, Catra, tend to hurt yourself in your self-destructive anger, and how you, Adora, can help both her and yourself."

Now infinitely more comfortable with Catra nuzzling close into her, Adora was almost enjoying this little- couples therapy- as Perfuma

had called it.

Almost, because as much as Adora enjoyed quality time with Catra, it really sucked that the topic at the moment was Catra hurting herself.

Adora wished she could say she had never done the same, but her own therapy sessions with Perfuma had uncovered that Adora was also prone to hurting herself, simply in a less obvious way than Catra. While Catra would bluntly dig her claws deep into her own skin as punishment to herself or in a fit of anger, Adora would throw herself into battle carelessly, with the intention of running herself exhausted or getting injured because she had believed she wasn't doing good enough at the time.

It was intentional.

It was self-harm.

At least, that's what Perfuma said.

Now, she was explaining to Adora the reasons for which Catra mainly did it, with the hybrid's consent and clarifications, of course. Much like shown in the situation with Glimmer, apparently, Catra self-harmed because of her need to alleviate the overwhelming anger and subsequently hurt herself *more* because she was punishing herself for feeling angry in the first place, even after several reassurances that it was okay to be angry. The

explanation hadn't been as detailed when Catra had told her, but Adora soaked in the information from Perfuma. And though the brunette remained mostly quiet, Adora could tell that Catra wasn't really ashamed of it. At least, not anymore. She figured it was a good thing. These therapy sessions were really helping the both of them more than expected, because Adora could remember times in the Horde when Catra would desperately chase her away, hissing and growling just so she wouldn't catch sight of the deep gouges and scars hidden beneath her fur.

"It's good that you remain calm in these situations, Adora. You've done quite well in learning to support Catra on your own, not judging and not forcing Catra to stop this behavior. That can simply cause more distress and we don't need that." She smiled warmly a the couple despite what she had just said, and Adora preened slightly at the praise before Perfuma continued, "However, I know you have a tendency to want to *fix* problems."

"Damn savior complex," she muttered from where her face was tucked into the crook of Adora's neck.

Perfuma's face morphed into a 'you're not wrong' expression and Adora gaped. They were ganging up on her, IN HER OWN THERAPY SESSION. "This is illegal, I'm sure it is," Adora pouted, "I'm going to tell Glimmer, and she'll pull out one of those fancy scrolls that have the Brightmoon laws in them, and then you'll all be done for!"

Catra smirked and pushed herself up to face Adora, "Well, as the person who helps Glimmer organize those scrolls, I can confidently say that this is not illegal, and if it was, I could easily

just burn it, she finished with a flick of her hand, which even while still bandaged, presented an incredibly strong argument.

"I suppose, if *that's* not illegal, then neither is this," Adora muttered, leaning in the few inches she needed to kiss Catra.

It was a light kiss, like most of their PDA were nowadays, especially after Glimmer had scolded them one too many times for making out in front of Frosta. But they both still blushed a little when Perfuma cleared her throat, staring at a random wall in the room. Frankly, they had forgotten she was there, but none of them made a big deal out of it when Perfuma simply chose to continue speaking to Adora while Catra went back to her nuzzling.

"Alright, continuing with the conversation, Adora, I know you typically want to help people, and you probably want to help Catra stop this behavior altogether, but I want to remind you that self-harm is still a coping mechanism, it simply isn't a very healthy one. And Catra has made tremendous progress in expressing herself." Slowly, and almost as if breaking some bad news to Adora, Perfuma spoke, "There is nothing to fix here."

The words took Adora back to only a few months ago when she and Catra had fought to the point of tears.

Adora had been upset because Catra wouldn't tell her anything about her nightmares or allow herself to be comforted.

"I just want to help you! Help you- help fix-"

"There is nothing to fix *, Adora! I'm not- I'm just struggling a little, I'm not broken! I'm not one of your little problems that needs fixing, stars, why can't you understand that!"*

Catra's claws dug into her head and ran shallow cuts down her face in frustration. It was all she could to keep from throwing something, to keep from hurting someone other than herself.

"Yeah, I understand," Adora replied with such sincerity that even Catra popped out of her spot with a slightly surprised, but fond look on her face.

Satisfied, Perfuma nodded and resumed her explanation, "Good, the most important things you can do for Catra when she reverts to this coping mechanism is reminding her of other, less harmful ones, and providing distractions. For example, Catra has revealed that many times, she prefers to get away from whatever situation it is that is bothering her, and simply going out to the gardens and woods. Alone," the word made Adora frown a little.

The thought of letting Catra just be alone with her thoughts in the woods seemed like something that would do more harm than good- counterproductive, almost, but Adora also knew that sometimes Catra needed to cool off. She was always less social than the blonde herself anyway.

"The most important thing in the moment is to stop the harm from happening at all, so just let Catra feel in control. Provide suggestions, let her feel supported and cared for but overall, Catra needs to be the one to choose. If she needs someone to listen to what she feels, you can be that person, if she needs space, give it to her, and then later on she may open up more."

"I love how you're both talking about me like I'm not here," Catra grumbled, but her purr gave away the fact that she was content not being directly addressed.

"This information will help the both of you, and I know you *are* listening, Catra."

"Yeah, yeah, I know how to help my idiot too, now," Catra paused, "thank you, for helping all of us. We'd be a mess without you," she chuckled.

A light blush made its way to Perfuma's cheeks, "Aw, it's my pleasure Catra. Everyone struggles with things, even me! I have a therapist of my own, you know? And really, I'm just so happy that I'm able to help you all with this new chapter of our lives, moving forward and such," she beamed.

Her smile was so contagious that even Catra smiled a toothy grin, watching Adora's own goofy smile appear on her face.

A quick goodbye and a hug later, Adora and Catra were walking back to the castle with Melog at their side.

They were looking forward to a night of food and rest, now that the chaos was over and they were emotionally drained, really. Unfortunately, reaching the entrance of the castle Glimmer chose to pop up in front of them, only saying a quick, “Have fun watching the prisoners!”, teleporting them to the spare room, and teleporting away again before Catra could get her claws on her.

Adora’s gaze fell on the hundreds of tied-up people, absentmindedly rubbing a dry-heaving Catra’s back while she contemplated abandoning her lover in search of food (she hadn't eaten all day, can you blame her?).

Eventually though, when Catra straightened up again Adora decided to be nice and simply propose a better option for the both of them.

"Do you wanna go raid the kitchen and just come back in the morning before Glimmer catches us?"

"Yeah."

Glimmer wasn’t too sure how supervising the reassignment of the crimson waste criminals was going to help her ‘relax’ as Bow had said after many, many teleportation trips with groups of people, but she stood in the dry desert land anyway, because Bow had so kindly asked her to.

She could have refused, it would have been completely justified with how annoyed she was at the fact that neither Adora nor Catra had done their job and led to perhaps one or two or twenty of the prisoners escaping. Glimmer was the one who had to chase them down, teleport them back to the castle, tie them up, and then teleport them *again* in groups to the crimson waste. It was far too early in the morning, and she would have much rather woken up with her forehead resting on the kitchen counter and a cookie halfway up her mouth while she drooled, like Adora did. Or even sprawled across the top of the cabinets with frosting all over her face and snoring, like Catra so pleasantly experienced this morning.

But no.

She was tired, thirsty, and just about ready to collapse standing next to Huntara, but the sight of the people who invaded her home marching out into the prime bot's current land made her pause in her self-wallowing. They were weaponless aside from a few daggers and bows and arrows. Not that any of the archers could match up to Bow's skill, in her opinion. She was heavily biased, though.

Either way, there were no trick arrows or weapons of high caliber amongst the criminals. Taking down the bots would be nearly impossible, and Huntara knew it when she sent them out.

Far more interested now, Glimmer leaned forward a little and narrowed her eyes just in time to catch the first person going flying into the air after trying to attack the bots. "HA," she startled

Huntara with her high-pitched chuckle, but the purple-skinned woman joined her in laughing when she saw how the raiders were being trampled. The part of the crimson waste population that wasn't being punished stood right behind the first group sent in, but they made no move to help. It only made the scene more ridiculous. Glimmer was wheezing after hearing so many of the criminals be thrown around only to have to get back up and attack again. The part of Glimmer that had thrived in the action of the war was shining through, and the gleam in her eye worried Huntara slightly before the Queen teleported into the action, tiredness forgotten, taking down a prime bot that everyone else had failed to. She led the second charge now that the bots were more hostile, seeing the show of power as a bigger threat meant to be taken seriously.

Bow had been right, this *was* relaxing… but, the sentiment felt a little too familiar, almost like it would be better applied to someone else, someone named….

Adora.

Dammit, now Glimmer was a hypocrite for enjoying this.

Chapter End Notes

> Catradora is one of those couples that needs to have really good communication or they'll be breaking up every other week, and not like Seamista does.
>
> I just want to say, this fic is super unrealistic. As much accuracy as there might be in the information Perfuma mentions, one session isn't going to fix everything most of the time. Therapy is a longgg process, and even the smallest of things take time to work out. Therapy also doesn't always

help. In fact, my most recent therapist made things worse. If you do go to a therapist, remember to find one that works well with you, because not all of them will and it's okay to not want to see them anymore. I would provide links to find some, but I don’t really know where to start looking for one and there are probably organizations more suited for that.

If you made it this far, congrats! I thank anyone reading this for pushing through all my little rants, and if you liked the story kudos or comments would be very much appreciated, as well as any constructive criticism. If not, that's cool too, go find something good to read <3

If anyone would like the links to either my PTSD research or self-harm causes and coping mechanisms research, just ask and I'll put it in the comments. They include, again: causes, coping mechanisms for oneself, how to help someone else struggling, and a variety of other information.

End Notes

Look at me, getting into something I probably shouldn't. Again. All because of the anniversary. Not sure how many chapters this is going to be but I kind of have it planned out, nothing too long.

I hope you liked this first chapter even if it was a little boring at the start! Constructive criticism is very much appreciated :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!